



High-stakes battle: BJP president Nitin Nabin campaigning for Nainar Nagenthiran in Sattur recently.

S. Sundar
SATTUR

Other prominent candidates are D. Anandaraja (NTK), S. Velmurugan (Puthiya Tamilagam), and M. Ajith (TVK).

Seven years after the Centre sanctioned the construction of a flyover at Padanthall junction, the work has begun only now. The long-pending demand for a road overbridge in lieu of a railway gate on Sattur-Irukkangudi Road remains unmet.

While the VCK is seeking to consolidate its dominance, the PMK is looking to rewire the caste equations in the northern districts. The contest looks evenly balanced, with Adi Dravidar and Muslim voters aligning with the DMK alliance, and Vanniyars consolidating behind the AIADMK front

Udhav Naig

The party also won the Assembly elections in 2006 and 2021, though it was defeated comprehensively in 2011 and narrowly in 2016. A sizeable Muslim

population gives the party an edge.

Speaking to *The Hindu* in Keezh Paruthikodi during his campaign, Mr. Jothamani said, "It was a complete surprise. I had my doubts whether the party would accept me. When Annan [Mr. Thirumavala-



While VCK office-bearers acknowledge that winning the election may be difficult without the backing of Mr. Panneerselvam, his image as a local Vanni-year strongman – and the VCK leaders' closeness to him – has caused unease among a section of Dalits

voters. When Mr. Thirumavalavan contested from here in 1999 and in 2004, non-Dalit communities united against his assertive politics. "The situation has changed substantially in favour of the VCK over the past decade-and-a-half. The PMK's assertive Vanniyar-centric politics has meant that non-Vanniyar communities (including Dalits) and minorities are mobilising against the PMK and its allies," a local Dalit activist said.

The PMK has deep roots here – Kaduvetti, the home of its controversial leader, Guru, falls within the constituency, and PMK candidate Anbu Cholan is no pushover. A long-

DMDK leader says she is confident of winning in Vriddhachalam, where she is contesting as part of the DMK-led alliance. She adds that the alliance between the two parties is one based on ideology

INTERVIEW

S. Prasad
CUDDALORE

Our alliance with the DMK was driven by the district secretaries and the party. It was the unanimous opinion of all that we should align with the DMK, and that solidified our decision.

Several allies of the DMK, such as the CPI, the CPI(M), the VCK, and the MDMK are



Our alliance with the DMK was driven by the district secretaries and the party. It was the unanimous opinion of all that we should align with the DMK

propagating that the Secular Progressive Alliance is an ideological one. What is your party's position on this? Is the alliance between the DMDK and the DMK ideological?

Definitely. The DMDK has risen above caste, creed, religion, and language, as had been emphasised by *Captain* (Vijayakant) since the beginning. He always advocated equal justice for everyone, and rejected any divide between the rich and the poor.

poet] Subramania Bharati, “*Thani oruvanukku unavilayenil jagaththinai azhiththiduvom*,” which translates to “We will destroy the world if there is no food for even one individual,” is the concept of *Captain*.

Do you agree with DMK leader and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's stand that this election is a fight between Tamil Nadu and New Delhi?

This election is between the DMK-led alliance and the AIADMK. With the BJP holding power (at the Centre), he [Mr. Stalin] made that remark – it is his view.

The upcoming election being a four-cornered contest with Vijay's TVK emerging as a likely disruptor, do you think the results will be close or lead to a hung Assembly?

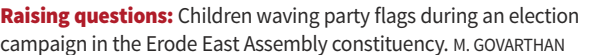
Everyone seems to think the election results will produce a hung Assembly, but I can't say for sure because the final decision rests with the people. The people's verdict is, in effect, god's verdict.

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami has commented on the DMDK's poor vote share...

I had already responded to this and given a detailed explanation during my visit to the Arunachaleswarar temple in Tiruvannamalai. Since then, he (Mr. Palaniswami) has not mentioned me, and I do not wish to speak about it any further.

You had previously lost in Vriddhachalam. What gives you the confidence that you will win now?

I am fully confident that I will win this time with a substantial majority of votes. We have been receiving strong and widespread support from everyone during the campaign. The foremost demand of the electorate is the formation of a new district with Vriddhachalam as its headquarters. There are also several other demands, including the revival of the ceramic industry to meet export needs.



The Hindu Bureau
ERODE

The presence of children at an election campaign in the Erode East Assembly constituency on Wednesday has raised concern over a possible violation of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC), which prohibits the use of minors in political campaigns.

The campaign was organised in support of Congress candidate Gopinath Palaniyappan. Several children were seen at the venue, with many of them waving party flags and appearing to participate in the gathering, despite the fact that political parties are expected to ensure that minors are not involved in election-related activities.

Parents who brought their children to the event defended their decision, citing the ongoing school vacation.

"We could not leave them alone at home, and hence we brought them along," a parent said.

mains largely urban, and the NTK lacks organisational depth.

In contrast, the DMK and the AIADMK rely on an entrenched grassroots machinery, with union secretaries leading campaigns and personally mobilising voters. With the election a week away, both the VCK and the PMK are relying on the organisational strength of the Dravidian majors to garner votes.

‘Vijay factor’

Interestingly, both the VCK and the PMK argue that the 'Vijay factor' would hurt the other. While the VCK claims the confusion in the PMK has pushed Vanniyar youth votes towards the TVK, the PMK argues that Dalit youth are unhappy with Mr. Thirumavalavan over his perceived failure to adequately address atrocities against Dalits.

TVK candidate S. Srinivasan, also the Cuddalore South district secretary, appeals to Dalit and minority voters. While Vanniyars in the DMK may hesitate to back the 'Pot' symbol when the PMK is contesting against it, Mr. Thirumavalavan's presence and involvement could become crucial in the final stretch of the campaign.



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State registers 99.92% pass rate in CBSE Class 10 exams

Tamil Nadu surpasses national pass percentage of 93.7; most students who felt their math scores were low due to a tough question paper are now preparing to take up the second exam this year

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu registered a 99.92% pass rate among students who appeared for the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) Class 10 board exams. This is a marginal increase from last year when the State registered 99.86%. The CBSE Class 10 results were announced on Wednesday, with the national pass percentage recorded at 93.7%. This year onwards, CBSE will be conducting two Class 10 board examinations for students in an effort to give the students a chance to enhance their performance and reduce their burden. As the exams concluded in March, many students had decided to take up the second set of examinations as their Math question paper was tough. The Chennai region climbed to third place in the country compared to last year's fourth with a pass rate of 99.58. The Class 10 exams began on February 17 and concluded on March 11. In Tamil Nadu, 60,730 boys and 50,873 girls wrote the Class 10 exams. Girls outperformed boys in this year's examination, with a pass percentage of 99.96, while boys stood at 99.90% pass rate. Most schools in Chennai city registered 100% pass rate. A total of 1,544 schools are registered and



A total of 60,730 boys and 50,873 girls wrote the Class 10 exams in Tamil Nadu. R. RAGU

CBSE has announced that students willing to appear for the second exam have to register through their school by April 20

The exams were conducted in 360 centers across the State. While schools in the city were happy about the results, many educators highlighted that students were interested in taking up the second examination for mathematics. N. Vijayan, senior principal of Zion and Alwin Group of schools noted that due to the tricky five-mark question in the mathematics paper, centums have drastically come down. "Due to this most

students have also shown interest to take up the second exam for mathematics as they are not happy with their scores," he said. He also added that this means added stress for all stakeholders and no vacations for teachers. P. Vishnucharan, Correspondent, Shree Niketan schools said that talks were held with parents and students before the results to assure them about the marks and admissions. "But many students were inclined to take up the exams to score better even if it did not impact their admission in the schools," he added. A Chennai-based parent said that while they had encouraged their child to write the second exam for mathematics due to the tough paper before the re-

sults they have now changed their minds. "But my child still wants to take it up as he really wanted to score above 95 but has only scored 85 now. We are trying to change his mind but he is disheartened with his scores despite preparation," she said. CBSE has announced that candidates willing to appear for the second exams will have to register through their school by April 20. The dates of examination will be announced later. Students can access their results through any of the four CBSE websites: www.cbse.gov.in; www.results.nic.in; www.results.digilocker.gov.in; or www.umang.gov.in. Students can access their result documents through the Digilocker app.

American Center to host student summer activities

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The American Center at the U.S. Consulate General, Chennai, has invited school students to explore 250 years of American excellence through free summer activities from April 20 to May 27. The "Freedom 250: American Excellence in STEM and Space" initiative will be open for students aged 13 to 17 (grades 8-12) and aims to engage young

minds through interactive Science Technology Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) learning experiences. Sessions will be held Monday to Thursday from 9:30 a.m. to 1:30 p.m., featuring hands-on activities with tools such as coding kits, electronic circuits, NASA Lego sets, 3D printing, and more. Students can also participate in daily quizzes and challenges, with prizes awarded to winners.

History-sheeter arrested for harassing woman

CHENNAI: A 24-year-old history-sheeter was arrested by the Puzhal police on Tuesday for harassing a woman. A senior official of the city police said Vikram, a resident of Lakshmiapuram, had been regularly harassing the 23-year-old woman to marry him. Initially she ignored him, but

recently he issued threats. Based on a complaint filed by the woman with Puzhal All Women police station, a case was registered. Police found that Vikram was involved in more than five criminal cases in Puzhal police limits. He was produced before a judicial magistrate and sent to prison.

Timings CHENNAI			
THURSDAY, APR. 16			
RISE	05:56	SET	18:22
RISE	04:45	SET	17:20
FRIDAY, APR. 17			
RISE	05:56	SET	18:22
RISE	05:29	SET	18:18
SATURDAY, APR. 18			
RISE	05:55	SET	18:22
RISE	06:15	SET	19:20

Chennai Weather			max	min
Tiruvallur			38	24
Chennai Airport			37	27
Chennai City			34	27

Chennai Airport Today
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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Fishermen of Srinivasapuram show black flags to Mylapore DMK candidate

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Residents of Srinivasapuram (Mullikupam and Mullima Nagar), a fishing hamlet near Forshore Estate, staged a protest against DMK candidate for Mylapore, Dha Velu, on Wednesday when he went to canvass for votes. Waving black flags and wearing black masks, they stood at the Amma temple at the entrance to the fishing hamlet. "We want the government to return to us the lands belonging to our village, where the housing board had constructed houses for government employees. The village owns those lands. We also want houses for those



Residents of Srinivasapuram protesting at the Amma temple at the entrance to the hamlet on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

who don't have houses. The DMK, in its manifesto for the 2021 elections, had promised to construct houses for us," said Sekar of Srinivasapuram. Community leader K. Bharathi said that it was the tradition of the community to take any MLA/MP or candidate visiting

the village to the temple and perform an archana. "It was not performed today. The people are upset with the DMK. It has not kept its promises. As the ruling party, they have only attempted to harass our people and take away as much of the beachfront as possible for various pro-

jects such as the Blue Flag beaches, the Marina Loop beautification, the Mamallan Reservoir, and the proposal to construct an elevated corridor from the Marina Light House to Injambakkam," he said. Local leader Nanjil Ravi said that dissent has been growing among fishermen and such protests will happen in more villages against parties that did not keep their promises. "Our people have considerable presence in 38 constituencies and they are all coming together to express their displeasure." Sitting Mylapore MLA Mr. Velu said the government constructed houses for the fishermen as promised. "They need more houses. That will be done."

CINEMA ARTS EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy, Madras
Today: 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall - The Music Academy Madras - HCL Concerts - Bharatanatyam recital by Nanda Kishore.

Arulmigu Sri Kapaleeswarar Temple, Mylapore, Chennai
Panguni Peruvizha and Vidai-aatri Music and Dance Festival. Today 16-04-2026 Thursday 6:50 PM, Kaalam Urrutun Dhaayam, A Kathak Dance Theatrical Presentation by Students of Smt Jigyasa Giri, Devaniya School of the Dakshin Gharana of Kathak. All are Welcome.

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Today 6.15pm SVK Birthday Concert by Dr Sumithra Vasudev, Charulatha Ramanujam, B Ganapathiraman. Ragasudha Hall.

Narada Gana Sabha
Ph: 24993201
Today Mini Hall (Swami Haridhos Giri Hall)- Music - 6.30 pm Swathi Thirunal Day - Music - Kiran and Nivi (Sai Sisters)-Vocal, Gayathri Vibhavari (Violin), Sarvesh Karthik (Mridangam). All are welcome.

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INBRIEF



Bartimaeus Trinity Trust completes 20 years of service

Bartimaeus Trinity Trust, a group of like-minded professionals committed to providing holistic support to the visually challenged from economically weaker sections of society, conducted its 20th anniversary programme, ‘Faith Beyond Sight’, in the city on Saturday. President of the Trust, Kuruvilla Thomas, said Ikkadu in Tiruvallur was identified as a primary area of intervention. He added that the trust has, over the years, implemented vocational training programmes in trades such as bag making, chair weaving, and envelope production. To build on its ongoing efforts, the trust proposes to establish a tuition centre for underprivileged children in the area. Bands such as the Living Stones Quartet and Men Aloha, performed at the event.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 16, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- What changed in Hungary's election? newsth.live/hungaryelection
- New brain-inspired ‘memristors’ promise to cut AI energy use newsth.live/energyreduction

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Parties converge on water but diverge on ecology in Tamil Nadu election manifestos

Most parties acknowledge climate change, but their responses take various shapes; citizen groups demand ground-level planning based on the ecosystem; a CWAC member calls for making public the Thiruppugazh Committee report on flood mitigation in Chennai Metropolitan Area

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

From river restoration and wetland protection to climate governance and industrial accountability, environmental issues have found a place in the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly election manifestos.

A closer reading of the manifestos of the DMK, AIADMK, BJP, NTK, PMK, VCK, and CPI(M), however, shows that while parties partly identify similar problems, they differ in how they propose to address them.

Water security and river restoration run through almost every manifesto. The DMK proposes a long-term ‘Tamil Nadu Water Protection Action Plan 2056’, alongside projects such as the Clean Cauvery initiative. The AIADMK, too, centres its approach on river conservation, with promises to prevent sewage from entering rivers and to restore tanks and canals through the *Kudimaramathu* model.

The BJP promises large

desalination plants and urban river clean-up projects, especially in Chennai. The NTK, on the other hand, frames the issue as one of poor management, and calls for better rainwater capture and a complete ban on industries along riverbanks. Most parties acknowledge climate change, but their responses take different shapes.

The DMK’s approach is institutional, built around governance systems such as a dedicated department and AI-based weather monitoring. The AIADMK seeks to mitigate the effects of climate change with measures such as planting 10 crore saplings and introducing climate change into school curricula.

The BJP focuses on urban adaptation, proposing ‘Project Heat Shield’ to tackle rising temperatures in cities. The CPI(M) connects climate concerns to energy, pushing for renewable sources, and cleaner public transport.

Forests and wildlife

When it comes to forests and wildlife, the differenc-



Poll plank: While the DMK proposes a long-term water protection action plan, the AIADMK centres its approach on river conservation. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

es become more pronounced. The NTK stands apart for its biocentric approach, arguing that policy must prioritise nature itself. Its proposals include creating biological corridors, restoring forest ecosystems, and strengthening tribal land rights.

The DMK and BJP take a more programmatic route, focusing on species conser-

vation, wetland protection and, in the BJP’s case, forest tourism. The AIADMK concentrates on reducing human-animal conflict and increasing compensation for affected families.

The VCK frames the issue differently, calling for greater control of natural resources by the State and pointing to gaps in the implementation of tribal

rights. It also raises concerns about eviction in the name of conservation.

Parties also differ in how firmly they propose to act on industrial pollution. The PMK takes the strongest line, promising to shut down sand and stone quarries, ban single-use plastics entirely, and bring all wetlands under legal protection.

The NTK proposes stricter regulation through the ‘polluter pays’ principle, backed by real-time monitoring of industrial emissions. The DMK and CPI (M) focus on pushing industries towards zero-waste and circular economy models.

The BJP’s proposals in this area are more tied to infrastructure, with relatively less detail on regulatory enforcement. What is also missing, however, is the kind of ground-level, ecosystem-based planning that citizen groups have been calling for.

A manifesto compiled by the Chennai Wetlands Action Collective (CWAC), drawing from residents across the Pallikarandai-Ko-

valam watershed, calls for basin-level water governance, strict floodplain zoning, and an end to construction and infrastructure within wetlands.

Raju, a member of the CWAC, called for the public release of the Thiruppugazh committee report on flood mitigation in the Chennai Metropolitan Area. “It is being said that the report identified several power transmission towers erected by State-run thermal plants on the Kosasthalaiyar bund, which leads to flooding. The report should be made public,” he says.

Poovulagin Nanbargal has put forward a set of 10 demands, including a dedicated policy for climate-vulnerable communities and the establishment of a specialised meteorological department to develop State-specific mesoscale climate models. G. Sundarajan of the organisation said, “Two decades ago, party manifestos did not even include sections on environment or climate change. This is progress, but it is still not enough.”

Girl attacked after she raises alarm against robbery attempt by 2 men

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Minjur police have arrested a 25-year-old man and are on the lookout for his accomplice in connection with an assault on a college student and an attempt to rob a house in Minjur on Tuesday night.

Rear entrance

The Avadi police said the college-going girl was in her room on the first floor of the house when two unidenti-

The Minjur Police have formed special teams to nab one of the accused who fled the scene of crime

fied individuals entered the building through the rear entrance.

As they proceeded to the first floor in an attempt to commit theft, she spotted them and raised an alarm.

In response, the intruders attacked the girl with a knife

before attempting to flee. She sustained cut injuries to her forearms and forehead.

One apprehended

Alerted by the girl's screams, her parents and brother caught one of the intruders who has been identified as Dillibabu.

The girl was rushed to the Government Stanley hospital for treatment.

The Minjur Police have formed special teams to nab the other accused involved in the case.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

K.V.MAHADEVAN (85 yrs)
Retd. civil engineer from PWD, College of Engineering Guindy class of '64, passed away peacefully at his residence on April 14, 2026, surrounded by his loved ones. He was incredibly warm and loving, and will be dearly missed by all.
Makka returns to the pavilion after a long and well bowied spell
Parvathi Mahadevan
Kaushik & Gopa
Padma & Rajagani
Karan & Sunaad
Zoe & Layla

DEATH

It is with deep sorrow that we announce the peaceful passing of our beloved wife, mother, aunt and grandmother
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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

THIRD ANNIVERSARY
Smt. LALITHA RAGHAVAN
D.O.B: 25.10.1933 D.O.D: 16.04.2023
We miss you .Continue to guide us as always.
FONDLY REMEMBERED BY
Son, Daughters, Sons in law, Daughter in law, Grandchildren, Great grandchildren, Relatives & Friends.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIRST ANNIVERSARY
Er.M. SHANMUGAM
25.03.1947 16.04.2025
You are always in our hearts
FAMILY & FRIENDS

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

DEATH ANNIVERSARY
IN LOVING MEMORY OF
Lalitha Sethuraman
30.05.1935 - 16.04.2025
Wife of Epigraphist
N. Sethuraman
Raman & Raman,
Kumbakonam
Chairman,
Eves Welfare Trust
Stree Rathna Recipient
Forever in our Hearts
Sankar Raman
Chitra Chandran
Indra Mani
Durga Sethuraman
Nirmala Sankar Raman

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

98th BIRTH ANNIVERSARY
Smt.T.K.D. SAROJA
16.04.1928 - 15.01.2022
Wife of late
Sri.T.K. Duraiswami,
Retd. Sr. Accounts Officer,
AG's Office, Madras,
(Prathama Acharya Purusha,
T.T.D.), Daughter of
late Smt.M S Pattammal and
late Sri.M Singarachari,
Advocate, Chittoor (A.P.)
Fondly remembered by :
Smt.Vijaya & Sri.N.S. Mohanram
Smt.Vatsala & Sri.V A Raghu
Sri.T.K. Balaji & Smt.Sheela Balaji
Smt.Mala & Sri.S. Ramakrishnan
Brothers-in-Law
Grand Children,
Great Grand Children &
Great Great Grand Children

DEATH

HOMAGE
January 8, 1935 April 12, 2026
Dr. Chalasani Radhakrishna
Past President of Indian Medical Association (Hyderabad North),
awardee of "Leading Professionals of the world" by Cambridge University, U.K.,
"Eminent citizen of India" and many more.
"In memory of a life so beautifully lived...
a heart so deeply loved"
a distinguished Doctor, a patient listener,
a true humanitarian, loved beyond words.
Smt. Hemalatha Chalasani
Sridhar & Sujini Chalasani
Sridevi & Murthy Nekkanti
Radhika & Gnyandeep Kantipudi
and his beloved Grandchildren
"Chalasani House", 1133, Srinagar Colony, Hyderabad-500 073

CENTRAL RAILWAY CONSTRUCTION WORK TENDER NOTICE
For & on behalf of President of India, Chief Engineer (C) RSP, Central Railway, G. M. Building, 2nd Floor, CSMT Mumbai 400 001 invites e-bids at e-Procurement website, "http://www.ireps.gov.in" for the following work. Sr. No:- 1., Tender Notice No. & date:- CONS-RSP-02-2026 dated 12.05.2026. Name of work:- Consultancy work for undertaking feasibility study, Detailed Project Report (DPR) preparation work, detailed design consultancy work including bid management in connection with the construction of 04 Nos ROB on replacement of existing ROB in APX Division on central Railway. Approx cost of work in Rs.:- 1,33,51,578.41. Bid Security Rs.:- 2,67,000.00. Completion period:- 08 months. Date & Time of closing:- 12/05/2026 at 11:00 Hrs. 1. Complete information of above e-tender notice is available on website "http://www.ireps.gov.in". 2. Bids other than in the form of e-bids shall not be accepted against the above Tender. 3. Tender documents and corrigendum issued from time to time are available on the website at least 15 days in advance of opening tender and may be seen on this website. 52
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense

AMARAVATI GROWTH and INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGICL)
APCRDA PROJECT OFFICE, 2ND FLOOR, AMARAVATI-522237 (A.P.)
E PROCUREMENT SHORT TENDER NOTICE
RFP. No. 02/JMD/CE/AGICL/2026/2nd Call, Dt. 15.04.2026
Name of Work: "AGICL-RFP for Selection of Firm for Design-Build of Shri Atal Bihari Vajpayee Ji "Smruthi Vanam" at Amaravati Exhibition cum Museum, Interpretation Centre, Library and Park" -Phase-I. The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 16-04-2026 to 23-04-2026 up to 14:00 Hrs. Due date for submission of Bid is 23-04-2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. Technical Bid opening date is on 23-04-2026 @16.00Hrs. For further details Please refer to www.apecprocurement.gov.in and www.agicl.org.
E PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
NIT No's:-
(1) 01/MAU61-USIOHB(BG)/8/2026-HB
(2) 130/PROC/MAU61-USIOHB(BG)/7/2026
(3) 131/MAU61-USIOHB(OTH)/124/2026-HB
(4) 132/PROC/MAU61-USIOHB(OTH)/125/2026-HB
(5) 133/PROC/MAU61-SIOHB(OTH)/121/2026-HB
(6) 134/PROC/MAU61-SIOHB(OTH)/123/2026-HB
(7) 135/PROC/MAU61-USIOHB(OTH)/122/2026-HB.
The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 16.04.2026 to 08.05.2026 up to 14:00 Hrs. Pre bid meeting Date 22.04.2026. Due date for submission of Bid is 08.05.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. Technical bid opening 08.05.2026 @16.00Hrs. For further details Please refer to www.apecprocurement.gov.in and www.agicl.org.
Sd/- Managing Director, AGICL, Amaravati

Civil Aviation Department
Airport Road, Patna – 800014.
TEL. No:- 0612-2225659, 2224423, Fax 0612-2224614, e-mail-cadbihaar@bihar.gov.in
Letter. No: वा०सं०नि० (शोजा) 09-17 / 2025 - 495 Patna, Dated :-15.04.2026
Corrigendum -02
(PR.27249 (CAD) 2025-26 & PR.000582 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27)
Subject: Corrigendum for "Air Services to New International Destinations " – Regarding
With reference to above mentioned subject, Due to unavoidable Circumstances, We hereby revise the last date of submission of tender on or before 28th April, 2026, 15:00 Hrs. Details of revised schedule is as below:-
1. Bid subject/work : Selection of Air Services to New International Destinations
2. Last date for submission of Bid : 28th April, 2026, by 15:00 Hrs.
3. Technical Bid Opening : 29th April, 2026, at 15:30 Hrs. (Tentative date)
4. Financial Bid Opening : Shall be intimated
5. Tender Bid Validity : 120 Days
Other terms and conditions of the tender published in PR.No. 27249 (CAD) 2025-26 and Corrigendum PR.000582 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27 shall remain unchanged.
Note : For details of tender and corrigendum, kindly visit the website; www.state.bihar.gov.in/cad
PR. No. 001112 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27
Secretary Civil Aviation Department
This information is available on website www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also
गर्भावस्था की पहली तिमाही में माँ की एच.आई.वी. और सिफलिस की जाँच जरूर कराये।



WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER
Date: 10.04.2026
E-tender is invited on behalf of the President of India acting through Chief Project Manager, Gati Shakti Unit, West Central Railway, Jabalpur, for the following work:-
T No.: CPM/GSU-JBP/EPC-01-2026, Dated 10.04.2026. **Name of work with location:** Major Upgradation of Jabalpur Railway Station of West Central Railway on Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC). **Approx. cost of the work:** ₹ 231.63,00,000/-. **Earnest Money:** ₹ 4.63,26,000/-. **Completion Period:** 30 Months. **Last date & time for submission of tender (up to 15.00 Hrs. on):** 28.05.2026. **Tender to be opened at 15.30 Hrs. on:** 02.06.2026. The complete information of the above e-tender is available on website <https://ireps.gov.in> and also placed on the notice board of the Chief Project Manager, Gati Shakti Unit, West Central Railway, Jabalpur. Tenders other than in the form of e-bids shall not be accepted against the above tender.
Assistant Divisional Engineer, Gati Shakti Unit, Jabalpur.
खच भारत अभियान
एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर



CENTRAL RAILWAY
CONSTRUCTION WORKS
Open Tender Notice No. Dy.CE/GC/KYN-ASO/02, dtd 13.04.2026
Office of Dy. CE(C) GC, Behind Reservation office, Jawahar Marg, Ghatkopar (E), Mumbai 400 077, Tele: Fax 25010315/66006 for and on behalf of the President of India invites "e-tenders" from reputed Contractors for the following work: **1 Name of work:-** Construction of Service building residential quarters and various miscellaneous work in connection with provision of 4th line between Kalyan Asangan project. **"(TWO PACKET SYSTEM).** **2. Approx Cost:-** Rs. 37,98,64,019.87. **3. Earnest Money:-** Rs. 75,97,300.00. **4. Completion Period:-** 12(Twelve) months including Monsoon. **5. Cost of Tender:-** Rs. 0.00 **6. Availability of Tender Documents:-** Tender document for the above work are available on website www.ireps.gov.in. **7. Date & Time of submission & Opening of Tender:-** The e-tender duly completed in all respect should be uploaded electronically up to 11.00 hrs on 06.05.2026 on the above mentioned website and will be opened after 11.00 hrs. **8. Important Note for tenderers:-** a) Prospective Tenderer/s are advised that before tendering their offer electronically, they should refer to the Tender details regarding terms and conditions, eligibility criteria, mode of submission of cost of EMD & tendered document. b) Central Railway has recently introduced system of "e-tendering". All intending Tenderers need to first register with IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in c) Tender documents and corrigendum issued from time to time are available on the above website at least 15 days in advance of opening Tender and may be seen on this website. **47**
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense



CENTRAL RAILWAY
ENGINEERING WORK
TENDER NOTICE
For & on behalf of President of India, Dy.Chief Engineer (Bridge Line) HQ @ Central Railway, G. M. Building, 2nd Floor, CSMT Mumbai-400 001 invites e-bids at e-Procurement website, ["http://www.ireps.gov.in"](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for the following work:- **SN:- 1. Tender Notice No. & date:-** CR-BR01/2026-27 dated 24.03.2026. **Name of work:-** Structural repairs and replacement of corroded/loose rivets & other steel members and painting of track girder bridges in various section(CSMT-CLA, CLA-TMBY, TNA-VSH) of Mumbai division. (09 bridges), **Approx cost of work in Rs.:-** Rs. 1,16,24,501.59/-, **EMD Rs.:-** Rs. 2, 32, 500/-, **Completion period:-** 09 months. **Date & Time of closing:** 05.05.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. **1.** Complete information of above e-tender notice is available on website ["http://www.ireps.gov.in"](http://www.ireps.gov.in). **2.** Bids other than in the form of e-bids shall not be accepted against the above Tender. **3.** Tender documents and corrigendum issued from time to time are available on the website at least 14 days in advance of opening tender and may be seen on this website. **48**
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense



CENTRAL RAILWAY
Rewiring works
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
No. 01/2026 OF 11.04.2026
For and on behalf of The President of India, invites open E-tender through website www.ireps.gov.in from reputed contractors. **S.N.:- 1. NAME OF WORK:-** Rewiring works for repair and renovation of officer's cabins and staff seating areas in Old & New Annex buildings, TMS buildings and other miscellaneous works at CSMT. **Tender No. 01/2026 (BB.L.G.W.CSMT.2026.01).** **Approximate Cost of the Work:-** Rs.2,35,99,216/-. **Bid Security:-** Rs. 4,72,000/-, **Validity:-** 60 Days, **Completion Period:-** 18 Months (C). **Instruction:-** 1. Tender closing date & time of aforesaid tender: Up to 13.00 hours of 04.05.2026 and will be opened after 13.00 hrs. **2.** The prospective tenderers are requested to visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for complete details of tenders & corrigendum, if any. **3.** Tenderer may participate in above e-tender electronically through website www.ireps.gov.in only & submission of manual offers against e-tender are not allowed. Manually, if submitted shall neither be opened nor considered. **4.** For further enquiry, may contact: Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer (General Service), Annex Bldg., 1st floor, Central Railway, Mumbai CSMT. **5.** This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy Order 2017 dated 15.06.2017. **46**
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WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY
Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, Bhopal.
No.: C/BPL/E-Auction/2026, Date: 15.04.2026
E-Auction for awarding contracts of Catering and Pay & Use Toilets
President of India, through Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager, West Central Railway, Bhopal Division, has invited E-Auction for awarding contracts of Catering and Pay & Use Toilets. Catalogues are available on IREPS Portal (www.ireps.gov.in). Details of catalogues are as follows:

Catalogue Number	Type of contract	Lot No.	Contract Period
C-BPL-CATG-SMU-	Catering	Catg-BPL-SHRN-SMU-174-25-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-ET-SMU-409-26-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-BAQ-SMU-75-25-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-NDPM-SMU-402-25-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-BHS-SMU-408-26-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-BPL-SMU-406-26-1	5 years
C-BPL-PNU-APRIL	Pay & Use	Catg-BPL-GUNA-SMU-91-25-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-BHS-SMU-66-23-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-GUNA-SMU-83-25-1	5 years
		Catg-BPL-NDPM-SMU-403-25-1	5 years
		PhU-BPL-BPL-Toi-14-23-1	3 years
		PhU-BPL-GUNA-Toi-23-25-1	3 years

Date and time of start of e-auction for all lots: 24.04.2026 at 12:00 Hrs.
All other details, Standard Condition of Contract and Special Condition of Contract are available on www.ireps.gov.in. Participants can visit the portal for details.
Divisional Railway Manager (C), West Central Railway, Bhopal
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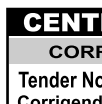
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ADMISSION NOTICE FOR B.DES & M.DES PROGRAMME 2026-27
Delhi Technological University invites applications for its Bachelor of Design Programme (B.Des) & Master of Design Programme (M.Des) for the academic session 2026-27. Application form for admission is to be filled online w.e.f. 16.04.2026 (Thursday) at 10:00 AM onwards till 15.05.2025 (Friday) 23:59 midnight through the University's website: www.dtu.ac.in.
Admission guidelines may be downloaded from the University website www.dtu.ac.in. For any query please mail to bdes_admission@dtu.ac.in for B.Des admission and mdes_admission@dtu.ac.in for M.Des admissions or contact at 011-27871017
-Sd/-
Registrar



Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-



CENTRAL RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM No. 1
Tender No. CR-BB-TELE-2026-30
Corrigendum No 1 is been issued for tender no CR-BB-TELE-2026-30
1. Tender closing date is extended up to 12/05/2026 15.00 Hrs. Details can be viewed on Website at www.ireps.gov.in Rest all other terms and conditions remain the same. This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy Order 2017 dated 15.06.2017
50
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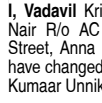
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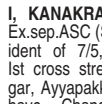
PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME



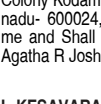
I, Vadavil Krishnakumar S/O, Vijaya Nair R/o AC 36, 3B, 3rd Floor, 4th Street, Anna Nagar, Chennai- 600040 have changed my name to Krishna Kumar Unnikrishnan for all purposes.



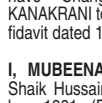
I, Hitherto known as Revathy Ravichandran D/o Ravichandran & W/o P.Joshwin Jabaraj Residing at No -4/18 , 5th Cross Street, United India Colony Kodambakkam, Chennai Tamilnadu- 600024, have changed my name and Shall Hereafter be known as Agathia R Joshwin.



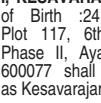
I, KANAKRANI wife of G.Perumal, Ex.ssp.ASC (South) No13822353, resident of 7/5, Karumariyamman Koil 1st cross street, Anna Anjugam Nagar, Ayyappakkam, Chennai – 600077, have Changed my name from KANAKRANI to P.KANAGARANI vide affidavit dated 13.04.2026 at Chennai



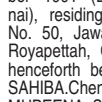
I, KESAVARAJ S/o.Raghupathy Date of Birth :24.09.1977 Residing at Plot 117, 6th Street, Ezhil Nagar Phase II, Ayyappakkam, Tiruvallur – 600077 shall henceforth be known as Kesavarajan



I, MUBEENA, S daughter of Thiru Shaik Hussain, born on 26th December 1991 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at Old No. 29, New No. 50, Jawahar Hussain1st Street, Royapettah, Chennai-600 014, shall henceforth be known as MUBEENA SAHIBA.Chennai, 27th June 2025. MUBEENA. S



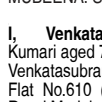
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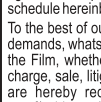
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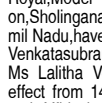
HEALTH
HAPPY FOOT SPA Reflexology Come as 2 & Pay 1 – @ Alwarpet. 72004 05144



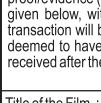
I, Venkatasubramanian Lalitha Kumari aged 70 years wife of Shri. N R Venkatasubramanian (Late) residing at Flat No.610 (Block C2) Casa Grand Royal,Model School Road extension,Sholinganallur, Chennai-600119, Tamil Nadu,have changed my name from Venkatasubramanian Lalitha Kumari to Ms Lalitha Venkatasubramanian with effect from 14 April 2026 vide notarised Affidavit No.307 dt : 13-04-2026. Henceforth, I shall be known as Lalitha Venkatasubramanian for all purposes.



I, TOMY SEBASTIAN, S/o Late SE-BASTIAN JOSEPH, aged 61 years, residing at Maha Flats, 15/17, Raghupathi Nagar, 1st Street, Nanganallur, Chennai – 600061, do hereby declare that my name has been wrongly mentioned as TOMY SEBASTIAN PULTHAKADIYEL in my passport. My correct name is TOMY SEBASTIAN as per my official documents such as Aadhaar Card, PAN Card, and Voter ID. Henceforth, I shall be known as TOMY SEBASTIAN for all purposes.



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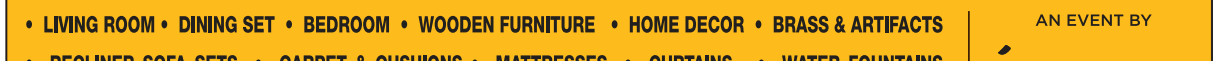
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BJP's failed Christian outreach attempt

The BJP may have to rework its social engineering strategies for creating a political space for itself in Kerala in the wake of these developments.

How proposed delimitation would redraw political map

Revising representation

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

Hotel-goers complain of decline in quality

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 16, 1926

Efficiency of British railways

It is explained that the high speed of British expresses, coupled with immunity from accidents, is mainly attributable to the quality of the rolling stock and of the permanent way. The Americans appear particularly impressed by the smooth running of the British trains.

From Page One

‘States seats will rise 50% after delimitation’

Asked how this position squares with the proposed amendments to the Constitution and the provisions of the Delimitation Bill, the functionary said everything would be explained during the parliamentary debate. “There is no change in the assurance given by the government that all States will have their number of seats in the Lok Sabha increased by 50%. If Tamil Nadu has 39, it will have 58; Kerala has 20 and it will have 30,” the functionary said, asking to wait for the mechanics of it to be explained in Parliament.

The drafts of the Bills have raised concerns that the States which have stabilised their population are set to lose their relative strength when the composition of the Lok Sabha is reapportioned between States as per the latest Census figures.

Iran threatens to close Red Sea traffic

Washington has sought to turn the screws on Tehran with the blockade, with U.S. Central Command saying that American forces “have completely halted economic trade going into and out of Iran by sea”.

Speaking to the *New York Post* on Tuesday, Mr. Trump said a new round of talks with Iran could take place in Pakistan “over the next two days”, while telling Fox Business the war was “very close to being over”. On the Iranian side, a Foreign Ministry spokesperson said “several messages” had been exchanged via Islamabad since the talks wrapped up on Sunday, while Tehran received a Pakistani delegation led by its Army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir on Wednesday.

Delimitation move will affect Punjab, says Akali Dal

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Shiromani Akali Dal president Sukhbir Singh Badal on Wednesday opposed the proposed move on delimitation.

The exercise is “brazenly discriminatory against Punjab”, he said.

Mr. Badal said, “Punjab is predominantly a minority-character state. We will be the biggest victim of this population-based delimitation. Compared with a nominal increase in seats for Punjab, Haryana will witness a nearly 100% increase [in constituencies] and get double the number of seats in the Lok Sabha. Where does that leave us? We are already a victim of systematic discrimination and injustice.”

Samrat Choudhary sworn in as Bihar’s first BJP CM

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The newly elected leader of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA), Samrat Choudhary, was sworn in as the Chief Minister of Bihar on Wednesday, marking the end of Nitish Kumar’s record tenure in the post.

Two senior leaders from the JD(U), Bijendra Prasad Yadav and Vijay Kumar Choudhary, took oath as Ministers. Both have been designated as Deputy CMs in the new BJP-led NDA government in the State.

Before being sworn in, Mr. Samrat Choudhary visited a famous Hanuman temple in the State capital, Patna, to offer prayers and seek blessings.

Senior BJP leaders, including party chief Nitin Nabin, Union Minister J.P. Nadda, and national general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santosh, along with Mr. Kumar, were present.

After taking oath, Mr. Samrat Choudhary went to the party headquarters to



Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary with former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar in Patna on Wednesday. ANI

meet party workers and leaders. “With the blessings of Nitish Kumar and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, I will take forward the work of development and growth in the State,” he told presspersons.

Administrative issues

In his first meeting as Chief Minister of Bihar, Mr. Choudhary directed State officials to implement a policy of “zero tolerance” against corruption with absolute firmness.

He also told officials to ensure that the general public received proper facilities and that their issues

INDIA bloc rejects delimitation move

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge reiterates Opposition’s stance that it is not against women’s reservation, but will not allow provisions in the amendment Bill to pass; Rahul Gandhi urges all MPs from the alliance to attend the Special Session, tells Trinamool that any absence will help BJP

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The Opposition Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) took a unanimous decision to vote against the delimitation provisions in the Constitution (131st) Amendment Bill, 2026, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said after a meeting of the alliance on Tuesday.

He said the Opposition was not against reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and Assemblies.

According to several members who attended the meeting both in person and online, the Trinamool Congress conveyed the message that not all its MPs might be able to be present in Parliament, drawing criticism.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said their absence “will help the BJP”.

Detailing the “dangers of delimitation”, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said barring one seat in Jammu, all went to the BJP.

Assam’s recent delimita-



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge with members of the INDIA bloc after a meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

tion was also cited as an example of possible gerrymandering in the garb of redrawing constituencies.

On Union Territories

CPI(ML) general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya, who joined the meeting virtually, highlighted the “alarming” rise in representation from Union Territories, from 20 to 35 members.

He said that the government could be planning to divide Bihar and West Ben-

gal to carve out Union Territories from Muslim-majority districts.

The Trinamool Congress was represented by its deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, Sagarika Ghose.

Objecting to Ms. Ghose’s remarks on the party’s inability to ensure 100% attendance, Mr. Gandhi said such a position was not acceptable. He urged all Opposition members to be present and to vote to defeat the Bill. “Their absence will come at a politi-

cal cost, and will be seen as helping the BJP,” he said.

The DMK, represented by T.R. Baalu, said that all its MPs would attend despite the ongoing election campaign in Tamil Nadu. Parties from Kerala pointed out that they were present for the debate on the FCRA law even amid the Assembly election in the State.

Ms. Ghose, sources said, argued that the Trinamool Congress alone is facing a head-on battle with the

being presented as a Bill in the Lok Sabha.”

The extended Budget Session in Parliament, reconvening on Wednesday, will deliberate on a legislative package comprising the Constitution (131st) Amendment Bill, the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Delimitation Bill, 2026.

The government has said these are aimed at expediting the implementation of 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies.

“All of us are in favour of the women’s reservation Bill, but have concerns about the way it is being brought. It is politically motivated. Just to gag and suppress Opposition parties, the government is doing this,” Mr. Kharge told reporters, reiterating the Opposition’s position that reservation should be implemented within the existing strength of 543 Lok Sabha seats for the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

“They (the BJP-led government) are playing tricks with delimitation,” he said.

BJP trying to ‘gerrymander’ all Lok Sabha constituencies in ‘anti-national’ act: Rahul



Rahul Gandhi

tuencies to its advantage for the 2029 election. “Having captured the Election Commission, PM Modi is confident that he can capture the Delimitation Commission too. The Congress will not allow this to happen,” he said.

“They are doing a dishonest thing. Prime Minister [Narendra Modi] doesn’t want women’s reservation done on the basis of caste census, new census, or the OBC census. He wants the 2011 Census in which the Backward Classes do not figure. He wants to take away your share,” Mr. Gandhi said.

“They don’t want you to get reservation on the basis of your actual strength. This isn’t just against the Backward Classes but an anti-national activity,” he added.

The Congress leader said that the enhanced Lok Sabha numbers and the allocation of seats after delimitation would adversely affect small States, southern States and northeastern States.

He said if the government was sincere about implementing women’s reservation, they should do it within the existing framework.

The Opposition leader

alleged that the women’s reservation amendments were not just an attempt to push through delimitation but also a diversionary tactic because of the Epstein Files, referring to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein. “Modi ji, I know that you want to send the message that you are pro-women. But you are scared of Epstein Files,” Mr. Gandhi alleged.

The Congress sharpened its attack against the government over its delimitation proposal on Wednesday, with the party’s communications chief Jairam Ramesh accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi of engaging in “deliberate deceit” on the issue.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh said the Bills circulated by the government ahead of the special sitting

of Parliament contradicted the “so-called assurances” given earlier by the Prime Minister on delimitation and a uniform proportionate increase in the strength of all States in the Lok Sabha. “The Prime Minister is a so-called leader whose only distinguishing feature is his unmatched ability to be a misleader,” Mr. Ramesh said, alleging that the proposed exercise would reduce the relative strength of southern States as well as smaller States in the northwest and the east in the Lok Sabha.

The Congress also accused the government of trying to sidestep the demand for a caste census. Party leaders claimed that delaying or avoiding such an exercise would prevent the availability of updated caste data.

Hoist black flags to protest delimitation move, says Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Describing the proposed Constitution amendment on delimitation as a “conspiracy” and a “black law”, DMK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday called upon the people of the State to hoist black flags in every home and in public places on Thursday.

“We will hoist black flags in our homes to express our protest and opposition to the amendment to be introduced in Parliament – a black law. Hoist black flags against the BJP, which is leading India into a dark period,” said Mr. Stalin, who convened an urgent meeting of party MPs and district secretaries.

In a video message, he said the BJP had consistently proved his point that the Tamil Nadu Assembly election on April 23 was a fight between Tamil Nadu and Delhi.

“It has understood the true meaning of our statement. It does not want Tamil Nadu to prosper, nor does it want the representatives of Tamil Nadu to be heard in Parliament. It is introducing an amendment to give shape to this conspiracy. How can we accept a conspiracy as law?” he asked.

“Hoist black flags against this black law in every home and public place. Let me warn you again: delimitation cannot be based solely on population. This black law must not be enacted. It is the single demand of eight crore Tamils. Let us transcend political barriers and raise our voice for the rights of the State. Tamil Nadu will fight and win. Let us win unitedly,” he said.

Mr. Stalin accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of reducing the southern States and their people to the status of secondary citizens.

“The time has come for us to tell the BJP in Delhi who the Tamil people are. The time has come to show opposition from every family to the BJP, which



M.K. Stalin

seeks to strangle the voice of Tamil Nadu,” he said.

He wondered whether this was a punishment for controlling population growth. “Will you snatch away our political rights even though we stand for the welfare and unity of the nation? Nothing could be more cruel than this,” he said.

The Chief Minister alleged that after claiming that the number of seats in the southern States would increase, the BJP government was planning to substantially raise the number of seats in the northern States, where it enjoys greater support.

“By this measure, it would make representation from the southern States less significant. We consider this a grave injustice,” he said.

Mr. Stalin said the BJP government, “which does not listen to good advice from anyone, is not listening to us either”.

Disparity in numbers

“They are bringing in an amendment to suppress the voice of Tamil Nadu in Parliament. It will create a disparity in the number of MPs representing the northern and southern States,” he added.

In the name of delimitation, the BJP government is overstepping its limits and betraying the interests of the southern States.

“Tamil Nadu will not remain idle if more political power is heaped on the northern States while the powers of the southern States are reduced. I have said that every family will take to the streets and protest,” Mr. Stalin said.

‘50% increase in seats is an illusion, a plan to mask fall’

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

Veteran Congress leader and former Union Finance Minister P. Chidambaram on Wednesday alleged that the proposed increase in Lok Sabha seats, followed by delimitation would reduce the proportional representation of southern States and weaken their voice in Parliament.

Addressing presspersons in Coimbatore, he said the plan to increase the total number of seats by 50% before carrying out delimitation was “an illusion” that would mask an actual decline in representation for States such as Tamil Nadu.

He said a direct delimitation exercise would have reduced Tamil Nadu’s seats from 39 to 32, which would have been evident to the public.

However, under the proposed method, he said, Tamil Nadu’s seats would first appear to rise to 58 before falling to 46 after delimitation.



P. Chidambaram

“People are expected to see only the increase from 39 to 46, but not the underlying reduction in proportional share,” he said, adding that voters in southern States would understand the implications.

He contrasted this with northern States, stating that Uttar Pradesh’s current 80 seats could increase to around 140 after the same process, widening the gap between States. “The disparity will grow from 80 versus 39 to about 140 versus 46,” he said.

Mr. Chidambaram said the combined share of the five southern States – Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka,

Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana – in the Lok Sabha would decline from 24.3% to 20.7%. “The voice of the southern States, which is already not adequately heard, will be further suppressed,” he said.

Urgency questioned

Mr. Chidambaram also raised concerns over the timing of the upcoming parliamentary session scheduled for April 16 to 18. He said Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had questioned the urgency in convening the session when the next general election is due in 2029.

Alleging a planned move, he said the timing coincided with peak election campaigning, making it difficult for MPs from Tamil Nadu and West Bengal to attend.

He claimed this was intended to limit opposition to certain amendments.

Despite this, he expressed confidence that MPs from the DMK-Congress alliance would attend the session.

CM
YK

Amazon.com said on Tuesday it would acquire Globalstar in an \$11.57 billion deal, bolstering its fledgling satellite business as it tries to catch up with Elon Musk's Starlink. Tech companies are pouring in billions of dollars to capture the lucrative market for satellite-based connectivity, but it will be a tall order to match Starlink's 10,000-unit-strong network. Through the deal, Amazon adds Globalstar's two dozen satellites to its existing network of more than 200. Amazon has been working to ramp up its network by deploying about 3,200 satellites in Earth's low orbit by 2029, with roughly half required to be in place by a July regulatory deadline. It is also preparing to roll out its satellite internet services later this year. Globalstar's satellite network is designed for reliable, low-data connections directly to mobile devices, or Direct-to-Device (D2D). REUTERS

Wholesale price inflation rose sharply to an over 3-year high of 3.88% in March, driven by a sharp spike in rates of fuel, power and manufactured items amid the West Asia crisis. Government data on Wednesday showed Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation rose for the fifth straight month in March as core inflation accelerated, amid softening of primary food items. As higher energy prices eventually generalise to other commodity prices, we expect WPI inflation to rise further in the coming months. The high WPI inflation in March reflects elevated global commodity prices and the impact of the energy price shock since the beginning of the West Asia conflict. WPI inflation was 2.13% in February, and 2.25% in March last year. Inflation in the fuel and power basket spiked to 1.05% in March, from a deflation of 3.78% in February. REUTERS

Travellers should brace for a costlier summer break as airfares have surged by more than 40% this April, rising even higher on leisure routes, as tensions in West Asia push up aviation turbine fuel costs and intensify operational challenges for airlines globally.

Data from travel booking portal Cleartrip show a Delhi-Mumbai ticket that

Leisure routes hit

The impact is more pronounced on leisure routes. Fares to Srinagar and Leh surged by 70%, climbing from ₹7,500 to ₹12,800, while hill destinations such as Shimla and Manali are

The 50-year-old firm, listed on the Tokyo Stock Exchange, started operations in India in 2017. The firm was distributing products through Medi Nippon to hospitals in Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Chandigarh, Bengaluru.

“The large Indian medical infrastructure, globally-renowned doctors and strong purchasing power is seeing a growth rate of 8% which makes it a high potential market for our products. Our long-term plan is to start manufacturing in India to make it a supply base for the Indian subcontinent as well as for African countries,” said Osamu Imazawa, president, Create Medic Co.

Katsuaki Yamane, MD, Create Medic India, said the firm will invest ₹20 crore in the next 2-3 years in India and then about ₹100 crore in another three years as they proceed to set up manufacturing facility.

two were appointed in place of Mehli Mistry and Pramit Jhaveri, who stepped down in February. Interestingly, Mr. Mistry has declared that he has “no desire” to rejoin the Trust board but that it should be run by “able, honest Trustees or an Administrator”. Earlier this month, Mr. Mistry had filed an objection with the Charity Commissioner against the presence of Vennu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh as trustees on the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution

on grounds of their not being Parsis and residents of Mumbai, as required by the trust deed.

Objecting to the Change Report filed by SDTT after his exit and the entry of new trustees, Mr. Mistry has contested his non-renewal as a trustee, arguing that it violates a 2024 resolution for mutual perpetual reappointments among trustees of SDTT and the other major trust, Sir Ratan Tata Trust.

Mr. Mistry has contended that the board that voted him out was illegal as

Exports posted the steepest fall in five months, declining by 7.44% in March to \$38.92 billion, while imports fell by over 6% due to the West Asia crisis, official data released on Wednesday showed.

wever, narrowed to a nine-month low of \$20.67 billion in March due to lower imports. Imports dipped by 6.51% to \$59.59 billion in March, driven by a significant decline in inbound shipments of crude oil and gold, the data showed.

For the full 2025-26 fiscal year, exports grew 0.93% to an all-time high of

\$441.78 billion, while imports rose 7.45% to \$775 billion. The trade deficit ballooned to \$333.2 billion due to a jump in gold and silver imports during the last fiscal. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal told reporters that the country's goods and services exports increased by an estimated 4.22% to an

all-time high of \$860.09 billion in 2025-26 against \$825.26 billion in 2024-25.

He said that despite global challenges, Indian exporters are showing resilience and are registering positive growth.

The secretary said that India's exports to the Middle East region fell 57.95% in March.

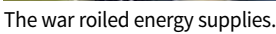
Gems and jewellery exports in the 2025/26 fiscal year dipped 3.3% from a year ago to their lowest level in five years, as shipments to top buyer the U.S. nearly halved, a leading trade body said on Wednesday, reflecting the impact of tariffs and duties.

Gem and jewellery exports in the year to the end of March fell to \$27.72 billion, the lowest since 2020/21, when COVID-19 pandemic-led lockdowns disrupted trade, and down from \$28.7 billion in the previous year, the Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJPEC) said in a statement on Wednesday.

Amid a global crude oil crisis triggered by the Iran war and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, India is likely to have lapped up most of the increased crude oil shipments from Venezuela and Russia.

As per BIMCO, one of the world's largest shipping associations, global crude shipments fell 16% after the war began vis a vis first 9 weeks of the year.

"This represents a re-



duction of 7.6 million barrels per day (mbpd) to 38.4 mbpd," BIMCO said.

With global shipments down, Venezuela increased shipments of

crude oil by 0.4 million barrels per day, as did Russia from the Black Sea by 0.8 mbpd. "Combined, this accounts for 85% of increased shipments from countries outside of the Persian Gulf. India has been the main destination for the increased shipments," BIMCO said.

The Hindu has been tracking open-source data for the past two weeks and found at least 17 tankers originating in Russia crossed the Suez Canal and bound for ports in India.

भारतीय राष्ट्रीय महासागर सूचना सेवा केंद्र

Indian National Centre for Ocean Information Services (INCOIS)

(पृथ्वी विज्ञान मंत्रालय भारत सरकार के अधीन एक स्वायत्त निकाय)

(An autonomous body under Ministry of Earth Sciences, Govt. of India)

"आशियन वैली", प्रतिगति नगर (बी.ओ.), निजामपेट (पि.ओ.), हैदराबाद-500090

"Ocean Valley", Pragathi Nagar (B.O.), Nizampet (S.O.), Hyderabad - 500090

विज्ञापन संख्या. INCOIS/RMT/01/2026

निम्नलिखित नियमित पदों को सीधी भर्ती तथा प्रतिनियुक्ति के आधार पर भरने हेतु पात्र भारतीय नागरिकों से आमंत्रित किया जाते हैं।

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क्रमांक S.No.	पद कोड Post Code	पदनाम Name of the position	पदों की संख्या No. of Positions
सीधी भर्ती Direct Recruitment			
1.	01,02,03	वैज्ञानिक सहायक Scientific Assistant	03 (02 UR & 01 ST)
प्रतिनियुक्ति पर On Deputation			
4.	04, 05	वैज्ञानिक 'सी' Scientist 'C'	02

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अंतिम तारीख: ऑनलाइन आवेदन प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तारीख **May 11, 2026** है।

Closing Date: The last date of submission of online application is **May 11, 2026**.

निदेशक/Director, INCOIS



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GAZA CITY

Gaza civil defence says toddler among 10 killed in Israeli strikes



Gaza's civil defence agency said on Tuesday that a toddler was among 10 people killed in separate Israeli strikes in the northern part of the Palestinian territory. At least 757 have been killed in Gaza since the truce came into effect, according to the territory's Health Ministry, whose figures are considered reliable by the UN. AFP

HONG KONG/MANILA

'China moves to block entrance to disputed South China Sea shoal'



China is employing ships and a barrier to tighten control of the entrance to the Scarborough Shoal in the South China Sea amid roiling tension with the Philippines over the disputed feature, satellite imagery obtained by Reuters shows. Scarborough is one of Asia's most hotly disputed maritime sites. REUTERS

WASHINGTON

Vatican should 'stick to matters of morality', says U.S. Vice-President



U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance urged the Vatican on Monday to "stick to matters of morality" amid an escalating row between President Donald Trump and Pope Leo over Iran. "It would be best for the Vatican to stick to matters of morality... and let the President of U.S. stick to dictating American public policy," Mr. Vance said. AFP

BEIJING

China to 'resolutely support' Cuba against sustained threats from U.S.



China will "resolutely support" Cuba against sustained threats from the United States, the Foreign Ministry said on Wednesday, days after President Miguel Diaz-Canel called for dialogue with Washington. Mr. Diaz-Canel insisted last week that he would not resign under pressure from the United States. AFP

Xi meets Russian FM as leaders flock to China over West Asia war

Russia could help offset China's energy shortfalls if shipping through Strait of Hormuz stays disrupted, says Lavrov; experts say China has leverage over Iran and could use it to press for restraint and diplomacy, especially as Gulf states seek stability

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China's President Xi Jinping met with Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov on Wednesday, Chinese state media said, as a string of leaders of countries impacted by the West Asia war flock to Beijing.

Mr. Lavrov joins Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez, Abu Dhabi's Crown Prince Sheikh Khalid bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan and Vietnamese leader To Lam in meeting with Mr. Xi this week.

The Russian diplomat told a news conference after meeting Mr. Xi that



Close ties: Sergey Lavrov with Xi Jinping prior to their meeting at the Great Hall of the People, in Beijing, on Wednesday. AP

Moscow could "compensate" for China's energy shortages as shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remains choked by the Iran war. Mr. Xi, mean-

while, has sought to position China as a mediator and stable partner in the face of the U.S.- and Israeli-led conflict.

Mr. Xi told Abu Dhabi's

crown prince on Tuesday that China would play a "constructive role" in promoting peace talks in the West Asia.

In talks with Spain's Sanchez, Mr. Xi warned that the world was facing "chaos and turmoil" and "a contest between justice and force", urging closer cooperation. The Spanish Prime Minister welcomed China's role in seeking to resolve the conflict in the West Asia.

Though the level of diplomatic activity is normal for Beijing, the West Asia war and particularly the issue of energy security have taken on new urgency in diplomatic discussions, ac-

cording to Dylan Loh, associate professor at Singapore's Nanyang Technological University.

"China has got leverage and influence over Iran, and there are some hopes that China can use this influence in a more direct way," Mr. Loh said.

Countries, particularly in the Gulf, could be hoping China can pressure Iran to stop its attacks on Gulf countries and to persist with diplomatic negotiations, he said.

Beijing and Moscow are close economic and political partners, and the relationship has deepened further since Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

Trump 'asked China's Xi' not to give Iran weapons

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Donald Trump asked Chinese President Xi Jinping in a letter not to give Iran weapons, and Mr. Xi responded that China was not supplying Tehran, the U.S. president told *Fox Business Network* in an interview that aired on Wednesday.

Mr. Trump, in the interview taped on Tuesday, did not say when the letters were exchanged. Last week, he threatened countries with an immediate 50% tariff if they supplied Iran with weapons.

"I wrote him a letter asking him not to do that, and he wrote me a letter saying that, essentially, he's not doing that," Mr. Trump told *FBN's* "Mornings with Maria" programme. He also said he did not expect



Donald Trump

shifts in the global oil market over the war on Iran and changes in Venezuela to impact the dynamics of his planned meeting with Mr. Xi next month. "He's somebody that needs oil. We don't," Mr. Trump said.

In a subsequent Truth Social post, Mr. Trump also wrote that he was "permanently opening" the Strait of Hormuz and China was very happy about it.

"I am doing it for them,

also - And the World," Mr. Trump wrote, adding: "President Xi will give me a big, fat, hug when I get there in a few weeks."

It was not immediately clear what Mr. Trump meant as shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remains constrained. The White House did not immediately respond to a request for clarification on the President's post.

Forty-five days after Iran's Revolutionary Guards declared the strait closed, effectively shutting in about 20% of global oil and liquefied natural gas shipments, transit through the waterway remains uncertain - even with the two-week ceasefire now in place. Traffic is at only a fraction of the 130-plus daily crossings seen before the war, sources said.

Teenager kills nine, wounds 13 in school shooting in Turkiye

Agence France-Presse
ISTANBUL

A 14-year-old armed with five guns opened fire at a Turkish school on Wednesday, killing nine people, wounding 13 and sparking scenes of mayhem as students jumped out of windows to escape.

The attack in the southern province of Kahramanmaraş was Turkey's second such incident in as many days, shocking a country where school shootings are a rare occurrence.

Interior Minister Mustafa Ciftci confirmed nine deaths, with 13 wounded - six in intensive care, three



Turkish police surround the school in Kahramanmaraş on Wednesday. AFP

of them in a critical condition.

Kahramanmaraş province governor Mukerrem Unluer said the attacker was the son of a former police officer. The attacker shot himself during the incident.

Israeli military strikes south of Beirut amid talks in Washington

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Two Israeli strikes on Wednesday hit vehicles south of Beirut, state media reported, while Hezbollah launched rockets at Israel, hours after Lebanon and Israel agreed to hold direct negotiations.

The Israeli military also renewed its call for residents of a swathe of southern Lebanon to leave as it continues to bomb the area. Despite its ongoing attacks, Israel has not targeted the Lebanese capital since a series of attacks across the country on April 8 that killed more than 350 people.

Lebanon's state-run *National News Agency* reported two separate Israeli strikes, both on the coastal highway around 20 km south of Beirut and outside Hezbollah's traditional strongholds.

The Israeli military, meanwhile, said it had detected "approximately 30 launches" by Hezbollah militants towards Israel since the early hours. Hezbollah said it launched rockets at 10 northern Israeli areas.

Meanwhile, United Nations refugee chief Barham Salih on Wednesday called on the international community to provide urgent support to Lebanon.

'Israeli support for Iran attack slumps'

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The latest Israeli Voice Index, a survey published by the Israel Democracy Institute (IDI), shows a decline in Israelis' support for Operation Roaring Lion - the country's term for the joint military attack carried out by the U.S. and Israel on Iran. The survey, conducted during March 22-26, also points to domestic fatigue stemming from persisting economic and security concerns.

An analysis of surveys show that the war has subsequently shifted Israelis' perspectives on the continuation and goals of Operation Roaring Lion. The latest figures are in contrast to the findings revealed by the previous surveys conducted during March 2-3 and March 9-11, respectively.



Israelis take part in an anti-government protest calling for an end to the conflict with Lebanon, in Tel Aviv on April 11. REUTERS

Data shows that when the U.S.-Israel attack on Iran began on February 28, an overwhelming 82% of Israelis supported the Operation to some extent. Almost three weeks later, this share declined by about 15 percentage points to 62%.

The share of Israelis who 'strongly supported' the operation declined further, from 64.4% in the initial week to about 42.7%

in the latest survey. This was a decline of almost 22 percentage points. Meanwhile, the share of those opposed to the Operation increased from 4% to about 12% in the same period.

In the previous surveys, at least 60% of Israelis believed that this operation would achieve its goals of destroying Iran's nuclear project and ballistic missile threats. However, in the

latest survey, only 24.4% of Israelis think that their society will be able to bear the burden of the war against Iran as long as it takes for the Operation to attain its goals.

While support for Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu still remains popular, it has also declined slightly, compared to the beginning of March. Over 64% of Israelis had then said that they trusted Mr. Netanyahu to manage the Operation properly.

Data shows that only 57% now hold the view that the Operation was primarily driven by strategic security-related considerations. This view is more popular among Jewish respondents.

A majority of Arab respondents hold that his motivations were mainly personal and political.

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IN THE MIX

Been a long road for me... plan is to keep playing: RCB's Hazlewood



K. MURALI KUMAR

It's been a bit of a long road for me the last few months... I got the rust out against Rajasthan Royals and felt the rhythm was good today [Wednesday]. The plan is to hopefully keep playing. Our schedule is pretty good from here on in... so fingers crossed I can keep playing — RCB pacer Josh Hazlewood.

BIG BOOST

England all-rounder Jacks set to link up with MI later this week



FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

England all-rounder Will Jacks is set to link up with Mumbai Indians later this week after missing MI's first few matches of the IPL. Jacks had taken time off following a demanding stretch of cricket, having featured in four of England's five Tests during The Ashes. He also played in the Sri Lanka white-ball tour and the T20 WC.

GREAT SIGN

'Tyagi bowling exceptionally well is a positive to take forward'



R. RAGU

I think Kartik Tyagi bowled exceptionally well, which is a positive to take forward into the next game. A young guy, he's had a number of setbacks... but to see him bowling fast and bowling well is a great sign. I was very impressed with the way he bowled against CSK — KKR bowling coach Tim Southee on Tyagi.

REPRIMANDED

Rahane fined ₹12 lakh for KKR's slow over-rate against CSK



R. RAGU

Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane has been fined ₹12 lakh for maintaining a slow over-rate during the IPL 2026 match against Chennai Super Kings at the MAC Stadium. "As this was his team's first offence of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct Rahane was fined 12 lakh," an IPL advisory said.

Vaishali wins Candidates, to challenge Ju for world title

Sports Bureau

R. Vaishali won the Women's Candidates chess tournament in Cyprus on Wednesday and thus qualified for the World championship match to be played later this year. The Grandmaster from Chennai scored a crushing victory over Russia's Kateryna Lagno in the final round to emerge as the clear winner.

Vaishali finished with 8.5 points, half-a-point more than Kazakhstan's Bibisara Assaubayeva, who was held to a draw by Divya Deshmukh. That draw ensured that Vaishali would go ahead of Assaubayeva in the points table. She will meet the reigning World champion China's Ju Wenjun in the title match. Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov had won the open section of the Candidates with a round to spare, and he will meet D. Gukesh in the World championship match.

Vaishali's younger brother R. Praggnanandhaa had a disappointing Candidates, finishing seventh in a field of eight, after scoring six points.

The results (final round):
Open: Andrey Espenko (Rus) 4.5 lost to Fabiano Caruana (USA) 7.5; R. Praggnanandhaa 6 drew with Hikaru Nakamura (USA) 6.5; Matthias Bluebaum (Ger) 6 lost to Anish Giri (Ned) 8.5; Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 10 drew with Wei Yi (Chn) 7.

Women: Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 7 drew with Zhu Jiner (Chn) 7.5; Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus) 7.5 lost to Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 5.5; R. Vaishali 8.5 bt Kateryna Lagno (Rus) 6.5; Divya Deshmukh 5.5 drew with Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 8.



Elated: Vaishali and her mother can't hide their joy after the Indian GM's fantastic show. FIDE

It's Vaishali's time to hog the limelight

P.K. Ajith Kumar

She started out as the lowest seed. She started slowly, drawing her first four games. And then she lost in the fifth round.

And yet, on Wednesday night at Pegeia, Cyprus, it was R. Vaishali who had the last smile. She staged a coup at the Women's Candidates chess tournament. She won the event, becoming the first Indian woman to do it.

She has qualified to play the World title match. Only one Indian has been there before: Koneru Humpy, one of the strongest players of all time in women's chess.

Vaishali will play the World title match against China's Ju Wenjun, which will be held later this year. She may start that event as the underdog, too. But Ju is unlikely to take her lightly.

Vaishali has the ability to raise her game at the right time. Like she did in Cyprus. After losing in the fifth round to Zhu Jiner, the top seed, she bounced back admirably, winning her next two rounds to get her campaign back on track.

Going into the last three rounds, she had a comfor-

table lead of one point, but she lost to her nemesis Zhu again, in the 12th round (the Candidates is an eight-player round-robin tournament). She drew the penultimate round to share the lead with Bibisara Assaubayeva. She showed her class in the final round encounter against Kateryna Lagno to write her own name in history books.

The Candidates is only the latest in the series of some stunning victories for Vaishali. She has won the Grand Swiss twice, thus earning the qualification for the Candidates in successive editions.

She is one of the few women to get the Grandmaster title and was part of the Olympiad-winning team. Till a few years ago though, she was overshadowed by her prodigious younger brother R. Praggnanandhaa.

She once told this correspondent how bad she felt when she first lost to him when he was a little boy. She considers it lucky she has such a strong player at home.

"And Vaishali can get even better," Grandmaster Pravin Thipsay tells *The Hindu*. "I believe she could beat Ju Wenjun."

Bowlers' day out as RCB coasts to victory against a listless LSG

The pace trio of Bhuvneshwar, Hazlewood and Rasikh comes up with a superlative effort to set up its fourth win of the season; Kohli comes in as an Impact Player, makes the top score; visiting team's skipper Pant struggles in his brief stay

IPL-19

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

Royal Challengers Bengaluru sauntered to its fourth victory in five matches this IPL season, beating Lucknow Super Giants by five wickets at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium here on Wednesday.

Chasing a modest 147, RCB got home with nearly five overs to spare to go top of the table.

Virat Kohli, who came in as an Impact Player, scored the most (49, 34b, 6x4, 1x6), but it was captain Rajat Patidar's two breath-taking sixes off Mohammed Shami - over long-on and above fine-leg - that will remain long in memory.

By T20 standards, much of the contest was slow-burn. The hitting was not manic, the atmosphere not so frenzied, and the 29,000 odd fans did not have as many moments as they usually would to let out the gasps and whoops. But even that will not help LSG from feeling tarred and feathered, as it came up with another abject batting effort.

It will also feel knackered, for Rishabh Pant, hit on his left elbow by Josh Hazlewood while batting, did not come out to keep.

After Patidar asked the visitors to bat, LSG started gingerly, scoring just 16 runs from the first 17 balls. When Mitchell Marsh hit



On a roll: Rasikh's incisive spell made Kohli's job easy. K. MURALI KUMAR



the last delivery of the third over - from Bhuvneshwar Kumar - onto the roof over square-leg, it was expected to have an unshackling effect.

What followed was the exact opposite. Aiden Markram was out in bizarre fashion, caught at cover off a full-toss down the leg-side by Rasikh Salam. Pant retired hurt off the third ball he faced, and Nicholas Pooran's wretched run continued (1,

Next assignment

RCB: April 18 vs. DC
Bengaluru, 3.30 p.m.

LSG: April 19 vs. PBKS
New Chandigarh, 7.30 p.m.

7b) as the excellent Hazlewood (4-0-20-1) forced him to play on.

Ayush Badoni (38, 24b, 4x4, 1x6) and Marsh (40, 32b, 3x4, 2x6) combined for 36 runs but run-rate was unsatisfactory. Badoni was involved in another

mini rescue-act with Mukul Choudhury (39, 28b, 3x4, 2x6), but a sharp catch from wicket-keeper Jitesh Sharma ended the former's stint.

At 118 for five, Pant came out to bat, with his elbow strapped. But his stay was short-lived, caught as he was by a diving Phil Salt at the square-leg boundary. That was Pant's last act on the field, and he found little joy in the dressing room too.

SCOREBOARD

LUCKNOW SUPER GIANTS
Mitchell Marsh b Krunal 40 (32b, 3x4, 2x6), Aiden Markram c Padikkal b Rasikh 12 (8b, 1x6), Rishabh Pant c Salt b Bhuvneshwar 1 (6b), Nicholas Pooran b Hazlewood 1 (7b), Ayush Badoni c Jitesh b Rasikh 38 (24b, 4x4, 1x6), Abdul Samad c Patidar b Krunal 0 (2b), Mukul Choudhary b Rasikh 39 (28b, 3x4, 2x6), George Linde (**Impact Player for Badoni**) c David b Bhuvneshwar 7 (7b, 1x4), Mohammed Shami b Bhuvneshwar 0 (1b), Avesh Khan b Rasikh 1 (2b), Digvesh Rathi (not out) 0 (3b); Extras (b-1, lb-2, w-4): 7; Total (in 20 overs): 146.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-32 (Markram, 3.6 overs), 2-35 (Pooran, 6.1), 3-71 (Marsh, 9.5), 4-83 (Samad, 11.2), 5-118 (Badoni, 15.5), 6-124 (Pant, 16.5), 7-137 (Linde, 18.3), 8-137 (Shami, 18.4), 9-145 (Mukul, 19.2).

RCB BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 4-0-27-3, Hazlewood 4-0-20-1, Rasikh 4-0-24-4, Krunal 4-0-38-2, Suyash 4-0-34-0.

ROYAL CHALLENGERS
Phil Salt b Prince 7 (8b, 1x4), Virat Kohli (**Impact Player for Suyash**) c Pooran b Avesh 49 (34b, 6x4, 1x6), Devdutt Padikkal c (sub) Himmat b Avesh 10 (11b, 1x4), Rajat Patidar c Digvesh b Prince 27 (13b, 1x4, 3x6), Jitesh Sharma c Mukul b Prince 23 (9b, 2x4, 2x6), Tim David (not out) 14 (8b, 1x4, 1x6), Romario Shepherd (not out) 14 (8b, 1x4, 1x6); Extras (lb-4, w-1): 5; Total (for five wkts. in 15.1 overs): 149.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-9 (Salt, 1.4), 2-66 (Padikkal, 7.2), 3-86 (Kohli, 10.1), 4-121 (Patidar, 12.2), 5-122 (Jitesh, 12.4).

SUPER GIANTS BOWLING
Shami 3-0-30-0, Prince 3-0-32-3, Digvesh 4-0-51-0, Avesh 4-0-23-2, Linde 1.1-0-9-0.

Toss: RCB. **PoM:** Hazlewood. *RCB won by five wickets with 29 balls remaining.*

Rohit's injury in focus for desperate MI

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

It has been a forgettable outing for Mumbai Indians so far, with just two points from four games. Adding to its woes, MI sweats over Rohit Sharma's fitness for the must-win IPL match against Punjab Kings at the Wankhede Stadium on Thursday.

Rohit had hobbled off after injuring his hamstring during the previous game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru and has since skipped practice, with the franchise maintaining that the "medical team is assessing" him. Rohit did some light, gingerly jogging on the eve of the game after skipping earlier training sessions. Later, he also spent some time in the nets, facing net bowlers.

A late call is expected, but if he eventually misses out, it will further dent a top-order that has lacked consistency. Rohit's ability to anchor and accelerate has often set the tone, and



Big question: MI sweats over Rohit's fitness as the former champion looks to get its campaign back on track. EMMANUAL YOGINI

his absence would only deepen Mumbai's early-season struggles.

Batting woes

MI has found the going tough, with its star-studded batting line-up failing to click collectively. Starts have not been converted, and partnerships have been hard to build.

On the eve of the game, Naman Dhir downplayed

concerns over the form of Suryakumar Yadav and Tilak Varma. While Suryakumar has scored 106 runs, Tilak has managed just 35 so far, though the team remains confident of a turnaround in fortunes.

The bowling unit, too, has been far from impressive. Jasprit Bumrah is yet to pick up a wicket despite being economical, while Trent Boult and Hardik

Today's match

MUMBAI INDIANS vs. PUNJAB KINGS

Mumbai, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 34
MI 17 | PBKS 17

PREVIOUS MEETING
PBKS won by five wickets, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOTSTAR

Pandya have lacked consistency at key moments, especially in the death overs.

Punjab Kings, led by Shreyas Iyer, appears more settled. Strong PowerPlay returns from Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya, along with middle-order stability, give the side the edge heading into the contest.

For Mumbai, another defeat could deepen a crisis in a season already threatening to drift away early, leaving little margin for recovery in a tightly contested league.

Noor's technical refinement does the job



Tactical nous: The KKR batters struggled once Noor found his length and speed. R. RAGU

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Royal Challengers	5	4	1	0	8	1.503
Rajasthan Royals	5	4	1	0	8	0.889
Punjab Kings	4	3	0	1	7	0.720
Sunrisers Hyderabad	5	2	3	0	4	0.576
Delhi Capitals	4	2	2	0	4	0.322
Gujarat Titans	4	2	2	0	4	-0.029
Lucknow Super Giants	5	2	3	0	4	-0.804
Chennai Super Kings	5	2	3	0	4	-0.846
Mumbai Indians	4	1	3	0	2	-0.772
Kolkata Knight Riders	5	0	4	1	1	-1.383

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

Chennai Super Kings turned Tuesday into another day of revival. The rhythm continued; so did the roars. A commanding 32-run victory over Kolkata Knight Riders didn't just help Super Kings join the cluster of teams with four points, but also rekindled the 'Fortress Chepauk' discussion.

At the heart of this resurgence was a reinvigorated spin attack, led by left-arm wrist-spinner Noor Ahmad, whose performance reflected both technical refinement and tactical maturity. "There was a bit more help from the surface today [Tuesday]," explained CSK's assistant bowling coach S. Sriram. "But, more importantly, Noor adapted well. He slowed it down through the air, got more side spin, and, crucially, more drop," Sriram said at the MAC Stadium. M.S. Dhoni has spent

time with the young Afghan and helped him sharpen his leg-break, revealed Sriram. "M.S. had a long chat with him at a practice session, getting his leg breaks to flow. That worked... as the results showed," said Sriram.

An in-game intervention, too, elevated Noor's performance. And it came from the other left-arm spinner Akeal Hosein, whose impact extended beyond his own bowling.

During the strategic time-out, the West Indian shared a key insight with Noor: find that "in-between length."

"Akeal was the one who told Noor about the 'in-between length' he needed to bowl. Once he figured that out, Noor became almost unplayable. I was part of that conversation and it really became a strategic break. Noor and Akeal complement each other very well. There is camaraderie between them and a lot of exchange of information too".

INBRIEF



Shubhankar goes to the top; Baisoya breaks course record

Shubhankar Sharma, *in pic.*, carded a second consecutive six-under 66 to take a two-shot lead after the second round of the inaugural Boulders Classic in Hyderabad on Wednesday. The 29-year-old moved to the top of the leader-board with a 12-under 132 while overnight leader Vishesh Sharma (65-70) slipped to third at 135. Honey Baisoya broke the course record with an immaculate round of 64 that propelled him from overnight tied 42nd to tied fourth at 136. He broke Vishesh's record of 65 set in the first round.

Infosys ropes in Alcaraz as global brand ambassador

IT services company Infosys on Wednesday announced it has signed up seven-time Grand Slam Champion Carlos Alcaraz as its global brand ambassador. Infosys will work with Alcaraz and his coaching team to develop an AI-powered match analytics and a personalised performance application to aid match preparation and in-game strategy. Beyond the court, the partnership also extends to joint initiatives between Infosys and the Carlos Alcaraz Foundation, to leverage technology to drive social impact, focusing on tech-for-good initiatives. Carlos Alcaraz is a champion athlete, recognised not only for his seven Grand Slam titles but also for being the youngest man in history to complete a career Grand Slam.



SUDHAKARA JAIN

Karnataka Badminton Association fetes Ayush Shetty

Ayush Shetty who claimed silver at the recent Badminton Asia Championship was felicitated by the Karnataka Badminton Association in Bengaluru on Wednesday. Ayush was awarded a cheque of ₹1 lakh by KBA president Kumar Bangarappa. Also present on the occasion were KBA member N.C. Sridhar and Ayush's parents.

TDCA to hold 'Scorers Education Seminar'

The Tiruvallur District Cricket Association (TDCA) will conduct a 'Scorers Education Seminar' on April 19 from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. Application forms can be downloaded from <https://tdcaindin.wordpress.com/> Photocopies of the following documents should be attached along with the application: digital birth certificate with QR code (or) valid Indian passport as age proof, and Aadhaar card as residential proof. Only candidates residing within Tiruvallur district limits are eligible to attend. Applicants must have completed 18 years of age. The last date for submission is April 18, 3 p.m. Applications should be sent via WhatsApp to 97101 95101 and the physical copy must be submitted on the day of the seminar.

TNCA LEAGUE

Singam Puli CC gets the better of AG's Office

G. Periyasamy's five for 32, followed by G. Rajalingam's unbeaten 54, guided Singam Puli CC to a four-wicket victory over AG's Office in a TNCA third division 'B' zone league match held recently.

In the sixth division 'A' zone, Krishna Sai's 105 and M. Sreejith's four for 57 proved decisive as St. Mary's edged past Jai Hind by a narrow seven-run margin.

The scores: III-B: AG's Office 191 in 41 overs (S. Ashwini Balaji 35, P. Francis Rokins 43, S. Maniraj 42 n.o., G. Periyasamy 5/32) lost to Singam Puli CC 196/6 in 42.2 overs (G. Rajalingam 54 n.o., Hunters XI 319 in 49.3 overs (B.K.



G. Periyasamy (Singam Puli, 5/32).



A. Rohan (Kohinoor, 5/36).



M.S. Rajeev (YMCA, 100).



R. Krishna Sai (St. Mary's, 105).



R. Mithun (Garnet, 6/28).

Samrith 69, S.S. Sharath Maalan 54, S.A. Bhavik Dariyo 61, J. Jai Suriya 41) bt Aruna 231 in 47 overs (R. Krishna Moorthi 62, V. Aakash 49 n.o., Abhinav Balaji 3/23, V.S. Tamizhdhasan 3/38). SNJ 200 in 44 overs (P. Sugendhiran 70, R. Hrishikesh Trilochan 49, S. Dinesh Kumar 3/18) bt Madras Aryan Club 171 in 42 overs (S. Somasundaram 43, R. Audhi Sachin 31, K. Barath Kumar 38, S. Rajesh 3/27, G. Rajaguhan 4/41). Prem 171 in 43.3 overs (K.

Laxman Arvind 59, C. Ashwin 32, K. Bharat Reddy 3/26, J. Joel Joseph 4/27) lost to IOB 174/7 in 40.3 overs (Abhishek Ashok 32, V. Varun 47). Fox Trotters 152 in 44 overs (Karan Hamir Sampat 40, S.N. Darshan 44 n.o., R. Mithun 6/28) lost to Garnet 153/3 in 22.5 overs (A. Vignesh 42, T. Kapil 34, Rahul 47 n.o.).

Triplcane SC 167 in 49.2 overs (B.J. Nithish Kumar 45) lost to Sir MCTM Old Boys 169/3 in 20.2 overs (M. Sathish 63, Om Ainesh Karthikeyan 84 n.o.).

overs (A. Kapil Sharma 82, K. Rajesh 31, G. Suresh Kumar 55, G. Ravishankar 3/43) bt Presidency College 169 in 29.5 overs (K. Arun Kumar 30, J. Daniel Raj 3/37). St. Mary's 206/4 in 30 overs (Krishna Sai 105, J. Sundaresan 40) bt Jai Hind 199 in 29.5 overs (S. Kishangandhi 35, Ajay Dueman 31, M. Sreejith 4/57, R. Sudharsan 3/58). Chennai Corporation 175/6 in 30 overs (S. Ashwin 32, Ganesh Gurrung 54, Thiru Vignesh 38 n.o.) lost to Eccentrics 180/5 in 27.4 overs (V. Aravinda Kumar 65 n.o., R. Vishaal 38).

VI-B: Amar 185/7 in 30 overs (L. Jai Hairsh 63, Bharath Sivakumar 42, K. Sathish 3/39) bt MFL 183/7 in 30 overs (K. Emasagar 69, R. Prajanth 40). Anna University 164/9 in 30 overs (T. Surendar 34, G. Madan Kumar 35, T. Arun Kumar 3/32) lost to TFUCC 167/8 in 29.4 overs (V.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA first division league, day two, Singam Puli vs Nelson (SSN); Jolly Rovers vs Vijay (IITM-Chemplast); MRC-A vs Young Stars (SRMC, turf); Grand Slam vs Jupiter (Guru Nanak); SKM vs Sea Hawks (Tagore); Globe Trotters vs Alwarpet (MRF-Pachaiyappa's), 9.30 a.m.

Atletico Madrid baulks Barcelona's riposte to reach the semifinals

Yamal, Torres fire the visitor level before Lookman settles the issue for the Madrid side; a Dembele double helps PSG end Liverpool's campaign



Pivotal: Lookman bundles in Atletico's only goal of the night to send his team through. AFP

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
MADRID

Atletico Madrid sent 10-man Barcelona crashing out of the Champions League and reached the final four with a 3-2 aggregate victory despite Tuesday's 2-1 quarter-final second leg defeat. Over at Anfield, Ousmane Dembele's double guided Paris Saint-Germain into the semifinals as a 2-0 win over Liverpool completed a 4-0 aggregate win for the holder.

Lamine Yamal and Feran Torres fired Barca ahead inside 24 minutes but Ademola Lookman's strike gave Atletico the edge in the gripping all-Spanish tie once again after its 2-0 win in the first leg. Diego Simeone's side returned to the semifinals for the first time since 2017 by holding on against the LaLiga champion in a compelling and bloody battle.

Barcelona defender Eric Garcia was sent off for bringing down Alexander Sorloth as he ran in on goal in the final stages, hampering its chances of finding a

third goal to force extra-time.

Liverpool will end the campaign trophyless after being kept at arm's reach by a PSG side that did not need to be at its brilliant best to reach a third consecutive semifinal.

Defeat means there will be no glorious goodbye for Mohamed Salah after nine memorable years on Merseyside.

The results (quarterfinals, second leg): Atletico 1 (Lookman 31) lost to Barcelona 2 (Yamal 4, Torres 24) (Atletico advances 3-2 on aggregate); Liverpool 0 lost to PSG 2 (Dembele 72, 90+1) (PSG advances 4-0 on aggregate).

NorthEast snatches a draw against Kerala Blasters

ISL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

After that morale-boosting victory in Bengaluru, Kerala Blasters was just two minutes of normal time away from another win, which would have been the first at home this season. But, that was not to be, as NorthEast United struck in the dying minutes to make it 1-1.

It was a lively match in which the two teams that have struggled in the ISL fought bitterly and created plenty of chances.

NorthEast's Andy Rodriguez was credited with an



Blasters players celebrate.

goal which put the host ahead with just four minutes remaining in the opening half. Fallou Ndiaye played the key role in the making of that goal.

Following a free-kick, Karim Benarif stormed into the box and found Ndiaye,

who first came up with a header and then a bicycle kick. And the ball travelled to Parthib Gogoi and then the unfortunate Rodriguez.

The Blasters looked like claiming another three points until substitute Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia struck for the visiting side.

The Blasters' goalkeeper Arsh Shaikh had come off his post, but failed to clear the danger from Robin Yadav, another substitute.

Lalbiaknia ensured the rebound would be the equaliser.

The result: Kerala Blasters 1 (Andy Rodriguez 41-og) 1 drew with NorthEast United 1 (Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia 88).

Singam Puli rides on Khader's first ton of the season; Saravanan and Chandrasekar shine

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau

M. Affan Khader's maiden century of the season (103, 195b, 12x4) steered Singam Puli to a strong position at 280 for six against Nelson on the opening day of the 11th round of the TNCA first division league at SSN College on Wednesday.

At IITM-Chemplast, left-arm spinner P. Saravanan delivered a sensational spell (18.4-3-39-7), well supported by off-spinner S. Lakshay Jain (three for 47), as Jolly Rovers bundled out Vijay CC for a mere 125 in the first innings. In reply, Rovers finished the day in a commanding position at 154 for one.

Meanwhile, at the SRMC ground, M. Mithul Raj



M. Affan Khader (Singam Puli, 103).



D.T. Chandrasekar (Sea Hawks, 7/29).



M. Ganesh Moorthi (SKM, 5/22).



Mithul Raj (Young Stars, 112).



P. Saravanan (Rovers, 7/39).

struck a fluent 112, while Aditya Varadharajan remained unbeaten on 87, the duo forging a crucial 178-run partnership for the third wicket to take their side Young Stars to 228 for three against MRC-A at stumps.

At Tagore College, Sea Hawks' left-arm spinner D.T. Chandrasekar produced a remarkable performance, claiming seven for 29 to skittle out SKM CC for just 77 in its first innings. The effort also brought his first-division career tally to 504 wickets.

However, SKM fought back through left-arm spinner M. Ganesh Moorthi, who picked up five for 22, but Sea Hawks secured a vital first-innings lead.

The scores (day one):

At SSN: Singam Puli 280/6 in 90 overs (K. Aashiq 40, U. Mukilesh 67, M. Affan Khader 103) vs. Nelson. **Toss:** Nelson.

At IITM-Chemplast: Vijay 125 in 44.4 overs (Abhinav Kannan 31, P. Saravanan 7/39, S. Lakshay Jain 3/47) vs. Jolly Rovers 154/1 in 45 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 86, B. Sachin 63 batting). **Toss:** Vijay.

At SRMC: Young Stars 228/3 in 90 overs (M. Mithul Raj 112, Aditya

Varadharajan 87 batting) vs. MRC-A. **Toss:** MRC-A.

At Guru Nanak: Grand Slam 236/5 in 87.4 overs (L. Suryaprakash 82, Akshay Sarangdhar 46, Arpit Vasavada 37 batting, R.K. Jayant 42) vs. Jupiter. **Toss:** Jupiter.

At Tagore: SKM 77 in 26.4 overs (D.T. Chandrasekar 7/29, Daryl Ferrario 3/23) & 55/3 in 14 overs vs. Sea Hawks 129 in 50.5 overs (M. Vishal 30 n.o., M. Ganesh Moorthi 5/22). **Toss:** SKM.

At MRF-Pachaiyappa's: Alwarpet 248/3 in 90 overs (L.R. Nawin 41, A. Badrinath 91 batting, P.S. Jaswanth 39, R. Ram Arvindh 48 batting) vs. Globe Trotters. **Toss:** Trotters.

AROUND THE CITY



Champion: The victorious Chennai Mass Riders squad receiving its reward. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chennai Mass Riders triumphs

Chennai Mass Riders posted a narrow 13-run victory over Freyer International Logistics Pvt. Ltd in the final of the Blue Sky Cricket Academy Knockout Trophy recently.

The scores (final): Chennai Mass Riders 203/7 in 25 overs (Aarif 75) bt Freyer International Logistics Pvt. Ltd 190/9 in 25 overs (Praanesh 34 Vanesh Bharath 3/17, Ajith 3/28).

Special Awards:

player-of-the-final: Aarif (Chennai Mass Riders); **best batter:** A. Karthik; **best bowler:** Praneesh (Freyer); **player-of-the-series:** A. Karthik (Chennai Mass Riders).

LIVE TELECAST

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & Fan-Code, 7.30 p.m.

IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.

Europa League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 10.15 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Friday)

For trade enquiry, contact: 7200143027, 9600162250

A CH-CH



K. MURALI KUMAR, AP, NAGARA GOPAL

First impressions and the lasting impact

It is up to Mukul Choudhary, Praful, Sakib and the others waiting to press their claims to build on these early gains if their ambitions are to snowball towards their logical end

R. Kaushik

GR Vishwanath, the wonderfully wristy stylist from Bengaluru, wasn't the first Indian batter to make a century on Test debut. Nor was the second. Or even the third. But he was the first Indian debutant centurion to score a second Test ton. And then a third, and a fourth, ending up with 14 hundreds when he played the last of his 91 Tests in February 1983. Remarkably, 'Vishy' never announced his retirement from the five-day game; dropped after a forgettable tour of Pakistan, he played First Class cricket for five more seasons before riding away into the sunset. Before him, Lala Amarnath, Deepak Shodhan, AG Kripal Singh, Abbas Ali Baig and Hanumant Singh all announced their arrival in international cricket with three-figure knocks. Not one of these five gentlemen would make a second hundred. Vishy, who celebrated his Test debut against Australia in Kanpur in November 1969 by erasing the bitter disappointment of a first-innings duck with 137 of the finest in the second innings, finally broke the jinx in February 1973.

Breaking the hoodoo

It took Vishy three and a half years and 25 innings to 'get the monkey off the back', as he recalls in his 2022 autobiography *Wrist Assured*. "I was beginning to think it was one of those things that happened for no reason," he writes of the no-second-hundred syndrome. "So, when I did touch three-figures in Bombay (as it was then), I was a relieved man. Subconsciously, I had started to believe that I would never replicate my feat in Kanpur. I wasn't desperate for a hundred, no, but I was still looking to get over 'the hoodoo', as it was called in Indian cricket circles. It was a milestone moment not just for me, but for Indian batting as a whole."

After Vishy, 11 more Indians have uncorked statement-making debut Test tons. Mohammed Azharuddin scored hundreds in his first three Tests, while fellow future captains Sourav Ganguly and Rohit Sharma slammed centuries in each of their first two matches. The last Indian to produce a ton on his maiden appearance was Yashasvi Jaiswal in July 2023; the prolific left-hander now has seven hundreds in 28 Tests.

To deliver the goods on one's maiden appearance in any sport at the highest level must be an indescribably fulfilling feeling with multiple ramifications. For one thing, it will explode the inevitable gremlins of self-doubt, of insecurity and a certain diffidence, of the inescapable if somewhat irrational consideration of whether one belongs. Especially in a team

sport, it will buy the individual a little bit of time to grow into their role. It will also raise the level of expectations, especially from an Indian context and more specifically from the context of Indian cricket because expectations and Indian cricketers have been inseparable bedfellows from the time Kapil Dev's intrepid warriors turned the world order upside down with their spectacular triumph at the 1983 World Cup.

It isn't just individuals that are nervous about their debuts. It won't be fanciful to suggest that apprehension was among the primary emotions the founding fathers entertained when the Indian Premier League kicked off at Bengaluru's M Chinnaswamy Stadium nearly 18 years back to the day. On 18 April 2008, Rahul Dravid's Royal Challengers Bangalore (as they were then called) locked horns with Ganguly's Kolkata Knight Riders. Less than six months previously, Dravid had stepped down as India's captain after leading the side for two years, having taken over from Ganguly who was sacked after five and a half years at the helm.

There was an understandable buzz about the IPL, conceptualised by Lalit Modi and given shape, even if belatedly, by the other visionaries in the Board of Control for Cricket in India. The IPL was projected as a mix of cricket and entertainment, with 'When opportunity meets talent' as its USP. The inaugural edition included the best players in the world in a format of which Indians had little taste. Or experience.

Of course, India's unexpected march to the title at the inaugural T20 World Cup in South Africa less than a half-year previously was just the shot in the arm the IPL needed. Until the World Cup, India had played exactly one Twenty20 International, against South Africa in Johannesburg in December 2006. With Dinesh Karthik in the forefront, India won a tense affair by six wickets, taking 19.5 overs to reel in the Proteas' modest 126 for nine. Virender Sehwag was the captain, it was Sachin Tendulkar's only T20I and there was no Dravid, Ganguly or Yuvraj Singh. Few remembered the game at the start of the World Cup, fewer still remember it now, but India's debut as a T20I side will remain memorable for the right reasons.

Just how much significance the Indian board attached to the T20 World Cup was evidenced from the grand launch of the IPL in Mumbai on 13 September 2007, even as first-time, left-field skipper Mahendra Singh Dhoni was masterminding a stunning coup in the land of the Big Five. It was, however, the World Cup success story that would headline the narrative in the lead-up to the start of the Indian Premier League.

A full house at the Chinnaswamy didn't

know what to expect or what was in store even as it partook of a glitzy opening ceremony marked by the promised entertainment and a fireworks display that left several in the stands with minor burns. One half of the bargain had been fulfilled. Now, it was over to the cricket.

For all its dalliances with glamour and Bollywood and afterparties in the initial few years, the IPL became a product to cherish and savour owing to the quality of the cricket. It was imperative for cricket to remain at the front and centre and no one understood it better, for want of a better phrase, than Brendon McCullum, the former New Zealand captain who is now under immense scrutiny in his role as England's all-format coach after his famed 'Bazball' approach hasn't managed to bring entertainment and success together.

But on 18 April 2008, McCullum was both entertaining and successful. Immensely so, providing the IPL with just the fillip it required in its very first match.

Magical knock

After Dravid chose to field, McCullum tore into the RCB bowling with a ferocity seldom witnessed at the Chinnaswamy. Numerous Test hundreds and double-centuries had been uncorked, but this mayhem was something else. One had to be present at the venue to grasp the full force of McCullum's pyrotechnics. The fours flowed regularly, 10 of them, but they were eclipsed by the sixes (13). In a matter of 73 balls, McCullum had taken the IPL to a stratospheric level with a subliminal unbeaten 158. Against Zaheer Khan and Praveen Kumar and Jacques Kallis and Sunil Joshi. The legend of the IPL had taken shape, entirely because of the magical luminescence of one man's ability.

In the years that followed, the IPL has grown from strength to strength. There have been seismic controversies, sure, but the tournament has been resilient enough to meet, tackle and overcome these challenges and set up shop as the unmatched No. 1 when it comes to franchise-based T20 leagues. And it continues to facilitate talent meeting opportunity.

Take Mukul Choudhary, for instance, in his debut season. And Praful Hinge and Sakib Hussain too, for that matter. Choudhary is a 21-year-old from Rajasthan, bought before this season by Lucknow Super Giants for ₹2.6 crore on the back of his exploits for his state in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. His first two IPL games were largely uneventful - 14 in a losing cause against Delhi Capitals, 2 not out off five balls and the best seat at the non-striker's end as his captain, Rishabh Pant, smashed three boundaries in five balls in the last over in a dramatic win over Sunrisers Hyderabad. Then came

Eden Gardens and Choudhary's chance to make himself a household name. He came in at 104 for five, which soon became 128 for seven; his team needed a further 54 for victory against KKR, and Choudhary had only his bowlers for support. Fear not, he seemed to say, during a furious onslaught that left the audiences in shock and awe. The 54 were knocked off in 24 deliveries; Avesh Khan faced just three of those as Choudhary went on a six-hitting rampage with Vaibhav Arora, Kartik Tyagi and Cameron Green at the receiving end. 54 not out off 27, two fours and seven sixes, made Choudhary a marked man, one to be watched and followed and scrutinised, especially with head coach Justin Langer promising to make him the best No. 6 or 7 to play T20s for India. Wow.

And what about Hinge and Sakib? Sunrisers Hyderabad, the 2016 champions, had made a poor start to their 2026 campaign with three defeats in their first four matches when they decided to shake things up. Out went IPL veterans Harshal Patel and Jaydev Unadkat for the showdown against Rajasthan Royals, boasting the precocious, precious 15-year-old Vaibhav Suryavanshi and a four-on-four unbeaten record. In came debutants Hinge and Sakib. Lambs to the slaughter, you say?

Yes, but not in the way it was perceived initially.

Dream debut

Skipper Ishan Kishan's enterprising 91 had lifted SRH to 216 for six in front of their loyal Orange Army, who brought the roof down in the first over of the RR chase. Within no time, Hinge packed off Suryavanshi, Dhruv Jurel and Lhuan-dre Pretorius, all for ducks, to leave RR reeling at 1 for 3. In the next over, Sakib had Jaiswal caught at third man, and Hinge returned in the third to pack off Riyan Parag, the rival skipper. 9 for 5, game over, sealed nicely in a lovely box with a ribbon on top. Hinge finished with four for 34, Sakib struck in his subsequent spells too to end up with even more impressive figures of four for 24. The former, from Vidarbha, is 24, the latter from Bihar is 21, both having honed their skills at the MRF Pace Foundation under Glenn McGrath. Like the IPL itself in 2008, they couldn't have hoped for anything more meaningful or substantial on their respective debuts. Like Choudhary, they are also surrounded by experienced, well-intentioned, well-meaning support groups who know what it takes to keep meteors grounded. It's up to them, Hinge and Sakib and Choudhary and the others waiting to press their claims, to build on these early gains if their ambitions are to snowball towards their logical end.

THE GIST

- ▼ To deliver the goods on one's maiden appearance in any sport at the highest level must be an indescribably fulfilling feeling with multiple ramifications
- ▼ For all its dalliances with glamour and Bollywood and afterparties in the initial few years, the IPL became a product to cherish and savour owing to the quality of the cricket
- ▼ In the years that followed, the IPL has grown from strength to strength. There have been seismic controversies, sure, but the tournament has been resilient enough to meet, tackle and overcome these challenges

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Fall in government's wheat procurement since last rabi season

69 in per cent. Wheat, the main rabi (winter) crop, is procured through the April-March period. However, much of the grain is bought in the first few months itself. The agencies have procured 15.30 lakh tonne so far since the start of the procurement operation from April 1. PTI

Amount Saudi Arabia is set to deposit in Pakistan's central bank

3 in \$ billion. The funds will provide a financial boost to Pakistan, where the economy has come under strain during regional tensions linked to the conflict between the U.S. and Iran. Authorities said earlier that the country would return \$2 billion deposited by the UAE in Pakistan's central bank in 2019. PTI

People missing in boat capsized in Andaman Sea

250 At least 250 people, including Rohingya refugees and Bangladeshi nationals, were missing after a boat capsized in the Andaman Sea recently on the way to Malaysia, according to the United Nations' refugee and migration agencies. PTI

The amount the EU is set to invest in 57 defence projects

1.3 in \$ billion. The European Commission said it will invest 1.07 billion euros in 57 defence projects in critical sectors such as AI, cyber security, drones and anti-drone systems. The investments are supporting the goals of the EU Commission's Defence Readiness Roadmap 2030. REUTERS

Japan's support for Southeast Asia amid the oil crunch

10 in \$ billion. The initiative, dubbed "Power Asia", will see Japan contribute 1.6 trillion yen to Southeast Asian nations to strengthen their energy supply chain and help them better procure crude and petroleum products. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What changed in Hungary's election?

What makes Viktor Orban's defeat significant? What led to his fall after 16 years? Who is Peter Magyar? What changes can Hungary expect? Does Orban's defeat signal the political limits of right-wing populism?

EXPLAINER

G. Sampath

The story so far:

In Hungary's general elections held on April 12, Viktor Orban (63), the Christian nationalist Prime Minister who had been in power since 2010, slumped to a shock defeat. His party, Fidesz, won only 55 seats (37.8% vote share) in the 199-member National Assembly. The Opposition Tiszsa Party, led by Peter Magyar (45), a former Fidesz leader, secured a two-thirds majority with 138 seats (53.6% of the vote), while the far-right Mi Hazank (Our Homeland Movement) won six seats (5.8% vote share).

What is the significance of Orban's defeat?

Under Mr. Orban, Hungary had effectively become an electoral autocracy. In 2011, he used his two-thirds majority in the National Assembly to pass a new Constitution that centralised power and eroded democratic checks and balances. A new law forced hundreds of judges to retire, who were then replaced by Orban loyalists, weakening judicial independence. He secured near-complete control over the media by selectively channelling government advertising and ensuring that critical outlets were either shut down or taken over by his loyalists.

He also manipulated Hungary's electoral system to his advantage through various means that favoured large parties like Fidesz, including granting voting rights to non-resident ethnic Hungarians in Central Europe and gerrymandering (redrawing electoral constituency boundaries to suit his party). These changes helped him win consecutive elections. With pollsters predicting another term for Mr. Orban, his loss came as a shock to the world.

Given how he had altered Hungary's democratic landscape and foreign policy and sought to project Hungary as a model



Peter Magyar cheers as he arrives at the entrance of the Presidential Sandor Palace on Wednesday. AFP

for 'illiberal democracy', his exit assumes historic significance.

What were the reasons for his defeat?

Political analysts have flagged four major reasons: a stagnant economy, high unemployment, a broken healthcare system, and a strong anti-corruption campaign led by Mr. Magyar. The rise of Gen Z voters also played a part. It was a key factor in the 76.5% voter turnout – the highest since Hungary's post-1990 democratic transition – indicating a widespread sentiment that this was a high-stakes election.

A growing public perception that Mr. Orban was running a 'kleptocracy', along with a stuttering economy, was a double blow that led to mass discontent and a yearning for change.

Who is Peter Magyar?

A former ally of Mr. Orban, Mr. Magyar broke away from the party and resigned from all government positions in 2024 following a political scandal in which the then-President had pardoned the head of a children's home who had been convicted of covering up child sexual abuse.

Mr. Magyar utilised the scandal to

reposition himself from a system insider to an Opposition leader. He amplified it by releasing a politically damaging audio recording of his ex-wife, Judit Varga, who was Justice Minister at the time and had countersigned the pardon. The recording was made secretly when they were still married.

Founding a new political party would have taken time and posed administrative hurdles, so Mr. Magyar joined the little-known Tiszsa party to contest the European Parliament elections. He won, becoming a Member of the European Parliament (MEP) in 2024. Soon after, he conducted a series of high-decibel media interviews and public rallies in which he accused the Orban regime of rampant corruption, repeatedly claiming that "a few families own half the country".

Ahead of the 2026 elections, he campaigned extensively across Hungary, advocating urgent change with the slogan, "Now or never". His mass mobilisation efforts paid off.

Does Magyar represent a clean break with the Orban era?

Yes and no. Mr. Magyar has the two-thirds 'supermajority' needed to roll back the anti-democratic constitutional changes

made by Mr. Orban, and he has promised to do so. He has also called on all of Mr. Orban's 'puppets' in the government to resign. Hungary's institutions, especially the judiciary and academic institutions, could regain some of their lost autonomy.

On the foreign policy front, there will be a clear break from Mr. Orban's pro-Russia, anti-EU stance, with Mr. Magyar going the other way – pro-EU and anti-Russia. In fact, his election rallies were marked by chants of "*Ruszkik, hazai!*" ("Russians, go home!") – a reference to the Hungarian revolution of 1956, when the country was under Soviet occupation, and an expression of resentment at Mr. Orban's close ties to Moscow. However, while he is likely to reduce Russian influence in government and support the EU's \$103 billion loan package to Ukraine – which Mr. Orban had blocked – he is not in favour of accelerating Ukraine's EU membership and is wary of being seen as overly pro-Kyiv. At the same time, he aims to reduce Hungary's dependence on Russian energy.

On immigration, Mr. Magyar could end up being tougher in material terms. He wants to cut back on the guest worker programme to protect Hungarian wages.

Does Orban's defeat mark the limits of populism?

Mr. Orban's populism had served as an ideological inspiration for similar political formations across the world, including the MAGA movement. Vice President J.D. Vance even visited Hungary to lend his weight to Mr. Orban's election campaign.

The combination of a skewed electoral system, an unlimited campaign war chest, and a clueless Opposition had made Mr. Orban appear invincible for 16 years. But a new political party led by an energetic leader demonstrated that even in an electoral autocracy, if the Opposition hits the streets and successfully engages younger voters, it may not be impossible to defeat a dispensation that uses populist policies as a cloak for rampant cronyism and economic mismanagement.

THE GIST

▼ Viktor Orban suffered a shock defeat, with a growing perception of a "kleptocracy" and a stuttering economy leading to mass discontent and a yearning for change.

▼ Peter Magyar led a strong campaign marked by anti-corruption messaging and mass mobilisation, securing a two-thirds majority and signalling a potential rollback of Orban-era changes.

Why is the Strait of Hormuz critical to global energy flows?

What is a maritime chokepoint? How does international law govern these waters?

Smriti Sudesh

The story so far:

Since late February, the Strait of Hormuz has emerged as the centre of a deepening energy and security crisis. The escalation followed U.S. and Israeli strikes on Iran, after which Tehran tightened restrictions on the narrow waterway. The situation intensified further this week when President Donald Trump ordered a U.S. naval blockade of vessels sailing to or from Iranian ports. As of April, a ceasefire has allowed a limited number of ships to pass through. However, continued threats and the U.S. blockade have kept most tankers away, reducing daily transits from around 130 vessels to just a few on several days.

What is a maritime chokepoint?

A maritime chokepoint is a narrow stretch of sea through which a large share of global trade must pass, with no easy alternative route. These are natural geographic bottlenecks created by

coastlines, islands, or narrow channels that concentrate shipping into tight corridors. Because ships cannot easily reroute, these chokepoints become critical nodes in the global trading system. Today, between 70 and 80% of the world's oil moves by sea, and much of it passes through such chokepoints. Even a single incident can disrupt traffic almost immediately. The consequences can be far-reaching. Energy prices tend to rise sharply, shipping costs increase and supply chains can be disrupted. This can lead to shortages of critical commodities, contributing to inflation and slowing economic growth.

Why is the Strait of Hormuz critical?

The Strait of Hormuz is widely regarded as the world's most important maritime chokepoint. It connects the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Indian Ocean and is a primary export route for oil producers in the region. At its narrowest, the strait is just 21 nautical miles (38 km) wide. Under normal circumstances, about

21 million barrels of oil – roughly one-fifth of global consumption – pass through it each day. In addition to crude oil, large volumes of liquefied natural gas from Qatar and the UAE also move through this route. Nearly 80% of these energy flows go to Asia, making countries such as India, China, Japan, and South Korea dependent on the route.

What are the other key global chokepoints?

Beyond Hormuz, the global trading system relies on a small set of equally critical maritime chokepoints. These include the Strait of Malacca, the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the Suez Canal, and the Panama Canal.

The Strait of Malacca runs between the Malay Peninsula and the Indonesian island of Sumatra. It forms the shortest sea route between the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea, making it a key route for trade between West Asia, Africa, and East Asia.

The Bab el-Mandeb Strait sits between the Arabian Peninsula and the Horn of

Africa. It acts as the southern gateway into the Red Sea, through which ships must pass before reaching the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean. This makes it a crucial link in the trade route between Asia and Europe.

The Suez Canal is an artificial waterway that cuts across Egypt, connecting the Red Sea to the Mediterranean. It allows ships to avoid the long journey around Africa.

Further west, the Panama Canal cuts across the narrow Isthmus of Panama, linking the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans. This makes it a vital route for trade between Asia, the Americas, and Europe, eliminating the need to sail around South America.

How does international law apply to these waterways?

The movement of ships through international chokepoints is governed primarily by the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. Under its provisions, straits used for international navigation are subject to the principle of "transit passage", which allows ships and aircraft of all nations to pass continuously and without obstruction. However, countries along the strait can regulate shipping for safety and environmental reasons, but they cannot stop ships from passing through or impose selective restrictions. This right of passage is broadly recognised under international law, though in practice, enforcement depends on naval strength and coordination between countries.

THE GIST

▼ The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow stretch through which about one-fifth of global oil and large volumes of LNG pass daily, making it central to global energy flows and trade.

▼ Blockades or threats can sharply reduce shipping, push up energy prices, disrupt supply chains.

